

AQUASHELLA RESEARCH DATA DUMP

Primary focus: Aquashella New Jersey 2026

Prepared as raw research material for a future *Tank Guide Life* podcast episode

Research compiled: September 14, 2026

HOW TO READ THE EVIDENCE LABELS

Label	Meaning
VERIFIED	Stated on an official Aquashella page, official venue/vendor/brand page, or a reputable industry publication, with a URL
LIKELY BUT NOT FULLY VERIFIED	Supported by one indirect or secondary source, or by a pattern across other Aquashella shows, but not confirmed for NJ 2026 specifically
PERSONAL/COMMUNITY OBSERVATION	Forum, social, or attendee-sourced; useful for atmosphere, not for hard claims
UNKNOWN	Could not be verified either way
FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY	Appears in your notes; no independent external source located

⚠ CRITICAL TIMING NOTE FOR THE WHOLE DOSSIER

Aquashella New Jersey 2026 took place **September 12–13, 2026** — two days before this research was compiled. **Post-event coverage, recap articles, exhibitor retrospectives, and creator walkthrough videos have not yet been published or indexed.** Nearly everything verifiable below comes from **pre-event announcements and official planning pages**, not from post-event reporting.

Practical consequence: *scheduled* is verifiable; *actually happened as scheduled* is generally not. Aquashella's own schedule pages carry the disclaimer that the schedule of events may change. This distinction matters a lot for several of the Section 4 items.

Source for dates/venue/schedule disclaimer: <https://aquashella.com/>

SECTION 1 — WHAT IS AQUASHELLA?

1.1 Core identity

VERIFIED — Aquashella brands itself as "The Largest Aquarium Expo In America" and "THE #1 EVENT FOR AQUARISTS." Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — Official self-description: the event brings together freshwater and saltwater aquatics, koi ponds, aquascaping, reptiles, and aquatic art, and is pitched at expert hobbyists, first-time visitors, families, and kids alike, framed around exploring, learning, connecting with experts, shopping, and seeing displays up close. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — A third-party exhibitor describes it as part expo, part festival, and open to the general public — a place to see gear in

person and talk to the people who build it. Source: <https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/>

Useful framing for audio: Aquashella positions itself as a *festival*, not a trade show. The official 2018 launch coverage explicitly framed it as not a "regular" reef show. Source: <https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/>

1.2 Founders and organizers

VERIFIED — Founded/spearheaded by **George Mavrakis**, known online as **CoralFish12g**. Sources: <https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/> ; <https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>

VERIFIED — **Shawn Hale** is identified as co-founder. Source: <https://www.gridnews.net/profiles/youtuber-turns-an-aquarium-hobby-into-a-globetrotting-journey>

VERIFIED — Mavrakis has said the founding idea came at the end of 2017 while he was studying abroad in London, after another large Chicago aquarium event shut down; he framed it as an opportunity to take aquariums to a mass audience. Source: <https://www.gridnews.net/profiles/youtuber-turns-an-aquarium-hobby-into-a-globetrotting-journey>

1.3 Structural components (the five pillars, per the official site)

VERIFIED — The official site organizes the experience into five buckets:

1. **Exhibitors** — freshwater, saltwater, reptiles, aquatic art
2. **Creators** — YouTube/Instagram/TikTok personalities, live streams, Q&A, photo ops ("Fish Stream")
3. **Educators** — **two stages** of speakers, entry-level through advanced
4. **Kids Activities** — Kids Corner/Kids Zone, crafts, aquarium-related activities
5. **Contests** — freshwater and saltwater competition Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — Kids programming also includes **Mermaid Cove** (face painting, sea-creature themes) and the **Fluval Kids Aquascaping Contest**, held at 1pm Saturday and 1pm Sunday in the Fluval Kids Aquascaping area. Source: <https://aquashella.com/for-kids/>

VERIFIED — A **charity raffle** is a recurring scheduled item (5:00pm Saturday, 4:00pm Sunday at NJ 2026). Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

LIKELY BUT NOT FULLY VERIFIED — A third-party blog states the charity raffle supports programs including "Pets in the Classroom." Not confirmed on an official Aquashella page for NJ 2026. Source: <https://shop.ageofaquariums.biz/blogs/news/aquashella-2025>

1.4 Recurring signature attractions across shows

VERIFIED (from official contest and schedule pages):

- Aquashella Aquascaping Contest (live, multi-day, cash prizes)
- Aquashella Scape Off / Speed Scaping (Feature Stage)
- Frag Off (coral fragging competition, Feature Stage)
- American Shrimp Contest
- Clownfish Contest
- Guppy Contest
- Koi Contest / Koi Showcase
- Stingray Competition (with Predatory Fins)

- Kids Aquascaping Contest
- Vivarium/Terrarium Contest
- Freshwater Jeopardy Live / Saltwater Jeopardy Live
- Open Mic "Tank Roast"
- Live DJ
- VIP Meet & Greet with creators Sources: <https://aquashella.com/contests/> ; <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://aquashella.com/aquashella-vivarium-contest/> ; <https://aquashella.com/>

1.5 Reptiles: officially part of the event

VERIFIED — Reptiles are an official, named category in Aquashella's own description of itself and its exhibitor lineup ("Freshwater, Saltwater, Reptiles, Aquatic Art and more"). Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — An exhibitor describes Aquashella as one of the biggest **aquarium and reptile** events in the country. Source: <https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/>

VERIFIED — Aquashella runs a formal **Vivarium Contest**: five designers, 8 hours on Saturday, building in a provided Vision Racks & Cages Model 322 (75-gallon, 36"L x 21"H x 23"D) enclosure with sponsor-provided substrates, decorations, and wood. Judging Sunday; winner announced at 12pm Sunday. Source: <https://aquashella.com/aquashella-vivarium-contest/>

VERIFIED — The Kids contest has expanded in some markets to "Kids Aquascaping and Terrarium Scaping." Source: <https://aquashella.com/contests/>

1.6 How Aquashella differs from adjacent event types

This section is **interpretive synthesis** built from verified facts. Label it as analysis, not as a sourced claim.

Event type	How Aquashella differs
Traditional trade show	Trade shows are B2B, badge-gated, buyer-focused. Aquashella is explicitly open to the general public, ticketed by consumer tiers (\$25–\$85), and features DJs, art, kids' face painting, and game-show segments. Aquashella <i>does</i> have a vendor/dealer access badge (\$60, two-day) for brand reps and local fish stores — so a light B2B layer exists inside a consumer event. Source: https://aquashella.com/vendor-rules-and-faqs/
Local fish club swap	Club swaps are volunteer-run, hyperlocal, cheap or free, and centered on hobbyist-to-hobbyist livestock trading and auctions. Aquashella is a touring commercial production across four cities with national brands, sponsor stages, cash-prize contests, and 100+ vendors. Source (NJ 2025 vendor count): https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/
Reptile expo	Reptile expos are typically livestock-purchase-driven, with tables of breeders. Aquashella includes reptiles as one wing of a much broader aquatic event, and formalizes the reptile side through a designed <i>vivarium</i> contest rather than primarily a livestock sale floor.
Reef convention (MACNA, Reefapalooza)	Reef-only conventions are saltwater-exclusive with a heavy scientific/technical speaker program. Aquashella deliberately mixes fresh and salt under one roof — that crossover was the founding premise in 2018. Source: https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/
Store event / in-store sale	Store events are single-brand, single-location, low production. Aquashella is a multi-day convention-center production with staged entry times, two stages, and a full contest calendar.

PERSONAL/COMMUNITY OBSERVATION — The fresh/salt/reptile mix is not universally loved. A NJ reef club member who attended the 2025 Edison show said mixing salt, fresh, and reptiles into one expo created large crowds of browsers, and rated the reef offering below Reefapalooza's. This is one attendee's opinion, not a consensus. Source: <https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/>

SECTION 2 — HISTORY AND EVOLUTION

2.1 Timeline

Year	What happened	Evidence
Late 2017	Concept formed by George Mavrakis while studying abroad in London, after a large Chicago aquarium event closed	VERIFIED — gridnews.net profile
Aug 18–19, 2018	Inaugural Aquashella, Chicago. ~80 companies, pitched as an even fresh/salt mix. Day passes \$15 (included a pair of UV glasses); VIP weekend pass \$75 with early access and first pick of livestock. Talent was art-led — coral art installations by ReefWeeds, Justin Credabel and others — rather than a speaker program	VERIFIED — reefbuilders.com, June 29 2018
2018 pre-launch	Announced as 80+ vendors, split 40 saltwater / 40 freshwater	VERIFIED — reef2reef article syndication, 2018
Mar 30–31, 2019	Dallas , Grand Place at Fair Park, 11am–6pm. Described as the only US event compiling all aspects of the aquarium industry in one convention, with aquatic-themed art installations throughout	VERIFIED — reef2reef sponsored article, Feb/Mar 2019
2021	Three cities: Orlando (Jun 12–13), Chicago (Aug 14–15), Dallas (Oct 30–31). Expected to draw roughly 30,000 across all three sites that year	VERIFIED — gridnews.net
2023	Contraction year: only Dallas and Daytona Beach ran; no Chicago, no Orlando. Community noticed and discussed it openly	VERIFIED (that it happened) / PERSONAL OBSERVATION (as to why) — https://www.reef2reef.com/threads/what-happened-to-aquashella-orlando.961789/
Nov 2024	Daytona show at the Ocean Center, Daytona Beach (shipping address for shrimp contest entries confirms venue)	VERIFIED — https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules
Sept 6–7, 2025	First-ever Aquashella New Jersey , New Jersey Convention & Exposition Center, Edison. Ticket price \$30	VERIFIED — https://reefs.com/event/aquashella-new-jersey/ ; PERSONAL OBSERVATION confirming it was the region's first: https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/
2025 (full year)	Dallas, New Jersey, and Los Angeles (Oct 25–26, 2025)	VERIFIED — https://aquashella.com/los-angeles/ and archived 2025 site navigation
Oct 2025	NJ 2025 reported as record attendance: 7,000+ attendees, 100+ vendors , with a notable koi/pond expansion	VERIFIED — https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/
2026	Four-city tour: Orlando Mar 14–15 (Dezerland Park), Dallas May 16–17 (Dallas Market Hall), New Jersey Sept 12–13 (NJ Convention Center, Edison), Chicago Sept 26–27 (Renaissance Schaumburg Convention Center)	VERIFIED — https://aquashella.com/

2.2 Format evolution — what actually changed

VERIFIED — From art-led to education-led. The 2018 launch coverage explicitly noted that instead of coral speakers and presentations, the talent would be art installations. By 2026 the official site advertises **two stages packed with speakers**, and the

NJ 2026 Speaker Stage runs a nearly continuous program both days. Sources: <https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/> ; <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — Freshwater and shrimp content grew into formal competition. The American Shrimp Contest was running at Aquashella Chicago as early as 2021, with a 50-tank cap and a ½-inch minimum shrimp size. By the current rules, the cap is **100 show tanks**, the minimum size is **¾ inch**, wild-type shrimp are barred, and there are **seven** judged categories. Sources: <https://www.simplenetix.com/e/american-shrimp-contest-at-aquashella-chic-tickets-75208> (2021) ; <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules> (current)

VERIFIED — Koi and pond became a strategic growth area in 2025. Mavrakis told POND Trade that 2025 brought in more koi and pond vendors than ever and that Dallas hosted a koi show; he framed koi as the intersection point where reef keepers and pond keepers turn out to be the same people. Source: <https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>

VERIFIED — Reptile/vivarium content was formalized into a judged Vivarium Contest with standardized 75-gallon enclosures and sponsor-supplied materials. Source: <https://aquashella.com/aquashella-vivarium-contest/>

VERIFIED — Creator programming was formalized. There is now a public **Creator Application** and a "Featured Creator badge," alongside Speaker, Vendor, and Volunteer applications. Source: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>

SECTION 3 — AQUASHELLA NEW JERSEY 2026

3.1 Core event facts — all VERIFIED

Field	Detail
Official event name	Aquashella New Jersey (2026 tour stop). Aquashella's own umbrella phrasing for the property is "Aquashella Aquarium Festival"
Dates	Saturday September 12 and Sunday September 13, 2026
City / State	Edison, New Jersey
Venue (as Aquashella lists it)	New Jersey Convention Center
Venue full/legal name	New Jersey Convention & Exposition Center (NJCEC)
Address	97 Sunfield Ave, Edison, NJ 08837
Nearby hotel listed by Aquashella	Sheraton Edison, 125 Raritan Center Pkwy, Edison, NJ 08837
Show hours	Saturday 10:00am–6:00pm; Sunday 10:00am–5:00pm
Entry model	Staged hourly by ticket type
Floorplan URL	https://aquashellanewjersey2026.expop.com/

Sources: <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://aquashella.com/nj-tix/>

3.2 Ticket structure — VERIFIED (published tier structure)

Tier	Door price	Presale price	Includes
VIP Weekend	\$99	\$85 + tax/fees	2-day wristband, 10am VIP entry, early-bird speakers, YouTube meet & greet, official show T-shirt

Early Bird	\$37	\$30 + tax/fees	1-day wristband, 11am early entry, early-bird speakers
General	\$30	\$25 + tax/fees	1-day wristband, 1pm entry
Kids (ages 5–12)	\$18	\$12 + tax/fees	Must be with an adult; entry time matches the adult; age 4 and under free

Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

Important caveat — VERIFIED: As of this research date, the site's presale pricing notes apply to **Chicago only**, and the **New Jersey ticket page reads that tickets are no longer available** (the show has passed). The NJ-specific tier inventory that was live during the NJ selling window is no longer publicly retrievable. Prices above are the published 2026 structure, not a confirmed NJ 2026 receipt-level record. Source: <https://aquashella.com/nj-tix/>

VERIFIED — how staged entry actually works: VIP weekend holders get the floor 10am–6pm Saturday and 10am–5pm Sunday with all-day re-entry both days. Daily ticket holders are scanned in within the hour their ticket names (an 11am ticket enters between 11am and 12pm), or any time after that window if late, with re-entry for the rest of that day. Kids' entry is tied to the accompanying adult's entry time. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — other ticket mechanics: Tickets are delivered digitally by email; they are **non-refundable**; day, time, or transfer changes are handled by emailing team@aquashella.com; staff can look up a ticket by ticket number or purchaser name if the QR code is missing; VIP T-shirts and VIP extras are redeemed at the **Aquashella Merch Booth**. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — vendor/dealer access badge: A two-day, full-access badge for brand reps and local fish stores costs **\$60**, reservable via sales@aquashella.com or at the Registration desk. Source: <https://aquashella.com/vendor-rules-and-faqs/>

3.3 Venue facts — NJCEC, Edison

VERIFIED / MIXED SOURCE FIGURES. Published exhibit-space figures vary by source; do not state one number as definitive.

Source	Figure given
ExpoFP venue page	155,277 sq ft of exhibit space, including 14,500 sq ft of multi-purpose meeting/function space connected to the main floor; room for over 7,500 people
Cvent	One large hall of 155,500 sq ft ; total meeting space 150,000 sq ft; exhibit space 110,000 sq ft; largest room 50,000 sq ft; 5 established meeting rooms; main ballroom 6,162 sq ft
Venue's own marketing / Yelp listing	"more than 150,000 square feet" / "approximately 150,000 square feet"
Northstar / AMI venue directories	Max exhibit space on a single floor 50,000 sq ft; theatre seating 6,240; banquet 3,500; classroom 3,932; ceiling height 24 ft; 600 booths accommodated

Sources: <https://expofp.com/njcec> ; <https://www.cvent.com/venues/edison/convention-center/new-jersey-convention-and-exposition-center/venue-2ad93327-042a-4647-aba3-8f941cefcf1b> ; <https://www.njexpocenter.com/> ; <https://www.yelp.com/biz/new-jersey-convention-and-exposition-center-edison> ; <https://www.northstarmetingsgroup.com/Meeting-Event-Venues/Edison-NJ/Convention-Center/New-Jersey-Convention-Exposition-Ctr-p52611911>

VERIFIED — Venue background: Established 1990; privately owned; hotels within a mile. Sources: <https://www.yelp.com/biz/new-jersey-convention-and-exposition-center-edison> ; Cvent listing above

Parking — CONFLICTING SOURCES. Flag this if you mention it.

- ExpoFP's NJCEC page states on-site parking is ample and **free**. Source: <https://expofp.com/njcec>
- A venue-directory listing states **1,200 spaces**. Source: <https://www.northstarmetingsgroup.com/Meeting-Event-Venues/Edison-NJ/Convention-Center/New-Jersey-Convention-Exposition-Ctr-p52611911>

- A ticketing aggregator lists paid lots ranging **\$5 to \$30 depending on event**, with valet. Source: https://events.sulekha.com/new-jersey-convention-and-exposition-center-tickets-in-edison-nj_venue_1044
- **UNKNOWN:** No official Aquashella page states the NJ 2026 parking arrangement or cost.

VERIFIED — Transit/access: Roughly 15 minutes south of Newark Liberty Airport, ~40 minutes from Midtown Manhattan, ~60 minutes from Northeast Philadelphia; rail access from Newark Airport Rail Link Station or NY Penn Station. An exhibitor separately noted NJ Transit's **Metuchen and Edison** stations are both close by. Sources: <https://expofp.com/njcec> ; <https://mindtrip.ai/attraction/edison-new-jersey/new-jersey-convention-exposition-center/at-KNsuv5IW> ; <https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/>.

3.4 OFFICIAL NJ 2026 SCHEDULE — VERIFIED

Reproduced from the official Aquashella schedule. Carries Aquashella's own disclaimer that the schedule may change. Source: <https://aquashella.com/> (New Jersey Event Schedule block) and <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>.

Saturday, September 12, 2026

Time	Festival Floor	Speaker Stage	Feature Stage
10:00am	VIP Entry	VIP Meet & Greet with Creators at 10:15am	VIP Meet & Greet w/ Creators @ 10:30am
10:30am	—	<i>Fishin' For Knowledge: Our Favorite Fish in Science</i> — Gettin' Fishy With It Podcast	Live DJ
11:00am	11am Entry	Aquashella Aquascaping Masterclass — Daichi Araki (presentation, substrate, hardscape)	Freshwater Jeopardy LIVE!
12:00pm	12pm Entry	Aquascaping Masterclass continued — Araki	Speed Scaping Contest — Round 1
1:00pm	1pm Entry	<i>What are Competitive Koi? Learn What it Takes to Win</i> — Fitz's Fish Ponds	Diverman Jeopardy ... Live underwater?
2:00pm	2pm Entry	Aquascaping Masterclass — Araki (planting)	Speed Scaping Contest — Round 2
3:00pm	3pm and later Entry	<i>What the L? An Introduction to Plecos</i> — Sabu Yamamoto, Saburai Aquatics	—
3:45pm	—	Panel: <i>Current Pressures on the Aquarium Trade</i> — Pet Advocacy Network and USAqua	Diverman Show — Live Interviews
4:30pm	—	<i>Building a Legacy</i> — Lori Barczyk, CEO/Founder, Legasea Aquarium and The Reptarium	—
5:00pm	Charity Raffle	—	—
6:00pm	Festival Close	—	—

Sunday, September 13, 2026

Time	Festival Floor	Speaker Stage	Feature Stage
10:00am	VIP Entry	—	VIP Meet & Greet w/ Creators @ 10:15am
11:00am	11am Entry	Aquashella Aquascaping Contest Awards	Speed Scaping Contest — Round 3

12:00pm	12pm Entry	<i>The Coral Food Nutrition Pyramid — Vanessa Glass, Home Brew Live Feeds</i>	Speed Scaping Championships
12:45pm	—	<i>Ethics and Best Management Practices for the Home Breeder — Jody Reed, Uncle Joe's Fish Shed</i>	Diverman Show and Tell
1:00pm	1pm Entry	—	—
1:30pm	—	<i>History & Development of the Tropical Fish Hobby — Livebearers! — Phil Marraccini, formerly of Summerland Tropical Fish Farms</i>	SHIZUKU Workshop Begins
2:00pm	2pm and later Entry	—	SHIZUKU Workshop
2:15pm	—	<i>Natural Aquarium Methods — Lou "Father Fish" Maxwell</i> (see name discrepancy, Section 4B)	SHIZUKU Workshop
3:00pm	—	<i>Foods and feeding your systems using science — Katrine, Kats Aquatics</i>	Saltwater Jeopardy
3:30pm	—	—	Diverman Show and Tell
4:00pm	Charity Raffle	—	—
5:00pm	Festival Close	—	—

3.5 OFFICIAL NJ 2026 FEATURED GUESTS (22 listed) — VERIFIED

From Aquashella's own "New Jersey 2026 Featured Guests" page: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>

1. Aquashella Man (*event mascot character*)
2. Dr. Plants
3. Brett Raymer
4. Predatory Fins
5. Polo Reef
6. George Mavrakís (*co-founder / CoralFish12g*)
7. Kaveman Aquatics
8. Leafy Street
9. Massimo Aquatics
10. KatsAquatics
11. **Grant Eder** (*The Garden of Eder*)
12. @the_macro_lady
13. @the_aquascaping_ryno
14. The Reef Vet
15. Dan The Turtle Man
16. Bella's Seahorse Beauties
17. Aquariums with Lefty
18. **Louis Foxwell** (*listed under the file name "father-fish" — see Section 4B*)
19. @balbibcn

20. Dustin's Fish Tanks

21. Octo Nation

22. Reefer_NYC

Note: This is the *featured guest/creator* list, which is not the same as the *exhibitor/vendor* list.

3.6 OFFICIAL NJ 2026 CONTEST LINEUP — VERIFIED

From <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/>

Contest	Official detail as published on the NJ page
Aquashella Aquascaping Contest	Sponsored by Fluval. Open entry, field selected by organizers. NJ page advertises a \$5,000 grand prize (see conflict below). Supporting sponsors shown: Aqua Natural, Betta Botanicals, West Coast Woodworks, Cherries Nature Aquarium, Sreepadma
American Shrimp Contest	NJ page says sponsored by Dymax (see conflict below). Supporting sponsors shown: AquaEL, Ultra Fresh Shrimp Delight, The Garden of Eder , Lucky Aquatics, and one unlabeled logo
Clownfish Contest	Designer varieties, bold patterns and rare morphs judged
Guppy Contest	Explicitly described as a consumer-decided event — the public decides best in show
USA Stingray Competition	In collaboration with Predatory Fins; \$1,000 cash prize
Kids Aquascaping Contest	Branded "Dustin's Fish Tanks" Kids Aquascaping Contest; Fluval and Aquascape Inc. logos shown
Aquashella Scape Off	Live aquascaping on the Feature Stage
Frag Off	Live coral fragging and propagation on the Feature Stage

⚠ SPONSOR AND PRIZE CONFLICTS — DO NOT STATE EITHER AS FACT:

- **Aquascaping contest prize:** NJ contests page says **\$5,000** grand prize (Fluval). The dedicated AAC entry page lists **Grand Champion \$1,000 / 2nd \$500 / 3rd \$250**, with 4th and 5th getting on-stage recognition. The general all-contests page describes the contest as presented by **Aqua Forest Aquarium x Aqua Design Amano** with a **\$1,000** grand prize. Three different framings on the same domain. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://aquashella.com/aac/> ; <https://aquashella.com/contests/>
- **Shrimp contest sponsor:** NJ contests page credits **Dymax**. An August 2026 registration announcement for the *New Jersey* shrimp contest credits **Hikari**. Both may be true (title vs. category sponsor) but the pages don't reconcile. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://reefs.com/shrimp-contest/>
- Several "Details & Entry" buttons on the NJ contests page point to an **unrelated external koi-show URL** (dallaskoikichi.org), indicating the page has stale/broken links. Treat everything on that page as directionally reliable but not carefully maintained.

3.7 Exhibitor / vendor list — MAJOR GAP

UNKNOWN / NOT RETRIEVABLE. Aquashella's NJ exhibitor page (<https://aquashella.com/nj-exhibitors/>) renders the list only through an embedded ExpoFP interactive floorplan, which is JavaScript-driven and returned no readable text. The floorplan at <https://aquashellanewjersey2026.expofp.com/> likewise returned no extractable exhibitor data. **No complete, citable NJ 2026 exhibitor list could be obtained.**

Worth noting: the NJ exhibitors page's embed reference still points at **aquashellanewjersey2025.expofp.com** in the page source, while the site navigation points at the 2026 map — another sign of stale page maintenance on the official site.

Individually confirmed NJ 2026 exhibitors (booth-level, VERIFIED):

Exhibitor	Booth	What they announced they were bringing	Source
AQUATOP	135	Three new all-in-one desktop systems: AquaFin 5-Gallon (AQF-05) , AquaFin 8-Gallon (AQF-08) , Ascension 9 (ASC-09) — all rear-chamber AIO designs, all set up and running at the booth. Plus rimless high-clarity tanks, bow-front glass aquariums, nano kits, filtration, lighting, heaters, pumps, accessories. Pairs the AquaFin with the Pisces 25W preset heater (PCS-25W)	https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/
ADA (Aqua Design Amano) with Aqua Forest Aquarium	223	Nature Aquarium built on a full ADA system; DOOA mini-Paludarium and DOOA Fully Automated System case for Paludarium; Daichi Araki masterclass Saturday; DOOA Glass Pot SHIZUKU mini-paludarium workshop Sunday	https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590

⚠ **TIME CONFLICT:** ADA's own release gives the Araki masterclass as starting **10:30am Saturday**. Aquashella's schedule puts it at **11:00am Saturday** (with a 10:30am podcast session before it). ADA gives the SHIZUKU workshop as **1:30–3:00pm Sunday** on the Feature Stage, which *does* match Aquashella's schedule. Sources: <https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590> ; <https://aquashella.com/>

Brands confirmed as 2026-season Aquashella partners (logos on the official partner wall — partner ≠ confirmed NJ booth): Tropic Marin, Aqua Natural, **Pet Supplies Plus**, Chemi-Pure, Deltec/RAD/JFA, AquaFX, Palm Street, Nu Aqua, Studio Aquatica, **Hikari**, Custom Cages, Lifegard, CaribSea. Fluval appears separately as mainstage/feature stage sponsor. Source: <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>

SECTION 4 — VERIFICATION OF YOUR SPECIFIC NJ 2026 OBSERVATIONS

Your observations were **not** treated as evidence. Each was researched independently.

A. Dustin's Fish Tanks

VERIFIED (presence): Dustin's Fish Tanks is listed on Aquashella's official **New Jersey 2026 Featured Guests** page. Source: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>

VERIFIED (role pattern): The Kids Aquascaping Contest is officially branded as the "**Dustin's Fish Tanks**" **Kids Aquascaping Contest**, and Aquashella's all-contests page instructs kids to check in at the **Kids Aquascaping Booth at Dustin's Fishtanks** by 1pm daily. Sources: <https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/> ; <https://aquashella.com/contests/>

LIKELY BUT NOT FULLY VERIFIED: That Dustin operated a **selling booth** at NJ 2026 with plants for purchase. At other Aquashella stops he has run a branded booth hosting the kids contest and has spoken on the main stage; his social posts about Dallas describe exactly that model. No NJ-2026-specific post about what he was selling was located. Source (Dallas pattern): <https://www.tiktok.com/discover/woshella-kolam-renang-bareng-dustin>

UNKNOWN: Any Dustin post specifically about Aquashella New Jersey 2026. Not found in indexed results.

FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY: That you bought Dustin plants at the 2025 NJ show and that two of them are still thriving a year later. Nothing external to verify — and nothing needs to be. This is exactly the kind of firsthand detail that earns its place in audio.

B. Father Fish

VERIFIED (presence and capacity): Father Fish is on the NJ 2026 **Speaker Stage** — *Natural Aquarium Methods*, **Sunday 2:15pm**. He is also on the NJ 2026 Featured Guests list. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>

⚠ **NAME DISCREPANCY — IMPORTANT, DO NOT REPEAT AQUASHELLA'S VERSION:**

- Aquashella's **schedule** calls him "Lou 'Father Fish' Maxwell."
- Aquashella's **guests page** lists him as "**Louis Foxwell**" (with an image file literally named `father-fish`).
- **Every independent source gives the surname as FOXWELL.** His own store's About page, a June 2026 local-TV segment, and an aquarium-science reference site all use **Lou / Louis Foxwell**. Sources: <https://fatherfishaquarium.com/about-us/> ; <https://www.mysuncoast.com/2026/06/06/a-list-talks-with-father-fish-master-natural-aquarium/> ; <https://aquariumscience.org/15-17-father-fish-aquariums/>

Conclusion: "Maxwell" appears to be an error on Aquashella's schedule page. Use Foxwell.

VERIFIED background: Lou Foxwell has over 70 years in fishkeeping; opened a tropical fish store as a retirement project after a career in ministry and community service; developed the **Father Fish Method** — a deep-substrate system built on soil, sand, and time; and served as a founding board member of the National Aquarium in Baltimore, chairing community relations and search committees in its early development. The business now operates from **Salisbury, MD** plus an online shop; the original Florida store has closed. Sources: <https://father-fish-aquarium.myshopify.com/pages/about-us> ; <https://fatherfishaquarium.com/about-us/> ; <https://aquariumscience.org/15-17-father-fish-aquariums/>

VERIFIED method summary (useful for the episode, and it sits close to Tank Guide territory): heavily planted with easy green plants; rich compost beneath roughly three inches of sand, planted carefully so the compost never contacts the water column; no CO₂, no chemical fertilizers; the stated philosophy is the aquarium as a self-sustaining ecosystem rather than a glass box with fish in it. Sources: <https://aquariumscience.org/15-17-father-fish-aquariums/> ; <https://fatherfishaquarium.com/about-us/>

C. LRB Aquatics

UNKNOWN for NJ 2026. LRB Aquatics does **not** appear on Aquashella's NJ 2026 Featured Guests page or the NJ 2026 speaker schedule. No official Aquashella NJ 2026 vendor listing could be retrieved to check the exhibitor side.

VERIFIED (elsewhere in 2026): Lucas Bretz of LRB Aquatics spoke at **Aquashella Orlando 2026** (March 14, 1:00pm Speaker Stage) on *No Filter Aquariums and Natural Setups*. Source: <https://aquashella.com/> (Orlando Event Schedule)

VERIFIED (LRB background): Home-bred livestock operation; ships weekly on Tuesdays; 8+ years shipping; tagline on TikTok is "CEO of NO FILTERS" with hundreds of natural aquariums. Sources: <https://lrbaquatics.com/> ; <https://www.tiktok.com/@lrbaquatics>

VERIFIED (historic Aquashella connection): LRB Aquatics' own Facebook has posted video of an Aquashella shrimp/aquarium display, confirming prior attendance at some Aquashella event — but not which one. Source:

<https://www.facebook.com/LRBAquatics/videos/i-need-this-in-my-life-one-of-the-displays-from-aquashellashrimp-aquarium-fishro/2417597255135216/>

→ If LRB was at NJ 2026, treat it as **FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY**.

D. The Garden of Eder

VERIFIED (presence): Grant Eder is on the official NJ 2026 Featured Guests list. Source: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>

VERIFIED (deeper role — this is a genuinely good find): The Garden of Eder is not just a vendor. **The Garden of Eder appears as a supporting sponsor of the American Shrimp Contest on the NJ contests page**, and the American Shrimp Contest's own rules page directs all contestant questions to "**Grant and Shelby**" at thegardenofeder@gmail.com. In other words, the shrimp contest is effectively administered out of The Garden of Eder. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>

VERIFIED (specialty and scale): Grant Eder, owner/operator, has been breeding shrimp for roughly a decade; placed three times in the first International Shrimp Competition held in the US in 2016, plus another in 2017; won Grand Champion at the Aquarium

Beautiful aquascaping competition at the Florida State Fair in 2017. Operation is based in Weeki Wachee, FL. Published counts have grown over time: 71 varieties in 125 tanks (2017), 130+ varieties across 300+ tanks and 40+ ponds (2022), and currently **140+ varieties of dwarf freshwater shrimp across 400–420+ aquariums**, plus nano fish, other invertebrates, aquascaping, and their own plant growing. Partner/co-operator: **Shelby** (Shelby Kaye Brown / listed separately as "Shelby Eder" on a 2026 Aquashella guest page). Sources: <https://www.raleighaquariumsociety.org/bio-grant-eder> ; <https://www.petliferadio.com/aquariumaniaep61.html> ; <https://gpasi.org/june-24-2022-grant-eder/> ; <https://www.facebook.com/tgoeshrimp/> ; <https://www.youtube.com/channel/UC5m7aFCiaT13JPiAglqtYSw> ; <https://aquashella.com/dallas-guests/>

UNKNOWN: Whether **Blue Diamond Neocaridina** specifically were offered for sale at the NJ 2026 booth. No source found. Blue Diamond is a well-established Neocaridina line they would plausibly carry, but plausible is not verified.

→ **Blue Diamond purchase = FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY.**

E. Hikari

VERIFIED (brand relationship): Hikari is a listed **2026 Aquashella partner** (logo on the official partner wall) — and the Hikari logo has been on Aquashella's partner wall since at least 2023 (logo file dated 2023/09). Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED (NJ 2026 specifically): An August 2026 announcement of American Shrimp Contest registration **for Aquashella New Jersey** — dated Sept 12–13, 2026 at 97 Sunfield Ave, Edison — states the contest is **proudly sponsored by Hikari**. Source: <https://reefs.com/shrimp-contest/>

⚠ **Conflicts with the NJ contests page**, which credits Dymax as shrimp contest sponsor. Flag rather than pick.

PERSONAL/COMMUNITY OBSERVATION (2025, not 2026): An attendee of the 2025 Edison show described waiting ~10 minutes at the Hikari area while a rep talked freshwater food — useful color for "Hikari staffs a real, busy booth at this show," but it's one forum post about the prior year. Source: <https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/>

UNKNOWN: Hikari's NJ 2026 booth number, specific products highlighted, or promotions run.

F. Seachem

UNKNOWN for NJ 2026. Seachem does not appear on any retrievable official NJ 2026 page (guests, contests, schedule, partner wall).

VERIFIED (strong pattern at other Aquashella stops): Seachem has had a prominent, heavily promoted booth at multiple Aquashella events, and creators have repeatedly hyped it — a Daytona 2024 video and a Dallas 2025 promo from KaveMan Aquatics both center on the Seachem booth as a gathering point. Sources: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KAimeCCdtLM> ; <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=w-XYvORI-zs> ; <https://www.facebook.com/KaveManAquatics/posts/the-2025-seachem-laboratories-crew-aquashella-dallas/1265337132264756/>

UNKNOWN: Any interactive game, giveaway, or promotion at the NJ 2026 Seachem booth. Nothing located.

→ **Seachem at NJ 2026, and any booth game/giveaway = FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY** (though it is a very plausible presence given the pattern above).

VERIFIED (brand context, useful regardless): Seachem's current product news includes an Axolotl Conditioner and Axolotl Buffer, and the company runs a "Mark of the Rhino" conservation match campaign with Mankwe Wildlife Reserve. Source: <https://www.seachem.com/>

G. SICCE

UNKNOWN for NJ 2026. No official Aquashella NJ 2026 page lists SICCE, and no SICCE announcement about the show was located.

VERIFIED (brand context): SICCE is an Italian pump and filtration manufacturer. Its most hobby-visible US product is the **Tidal power filter line, co-developed with Seachem** — a hang-on-back filter with a self-priming pump, dual intake with surface skimmer, adjustable flow, a maintenance monitor, self-cleaning impeller, and a large media basket that takes any media type.

Sources: <https://www.seachem.com/tidal-filters.php> ; <https://keepfishkeeping.com/products/tidal-power-filters-from-seachem-sicce>

→ **SICCE at NJ 2026 = FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY.** (The Seachem/SICCE Tidal relationship is a nice on-air hook if you saw both booths: two brands most hobbyists think of separately, sharing a product line.)

H. Fitz's Fish Ponds

VERIFIED — strongest single vendor confirmation of the whole list. Fitz's Fish Ponds delivered a Speaker Stage session at NJ 2026: *What are Competitive Koi? Learn What it Takes to Win*, **Saturday 1:00pm**. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED (2025 precedent): Fitz's Fish Ponds was named by POND Trade as a participating vendor at Aquashella NJ 2025, alongside RNR Koi, Poly Tank, Aqua Meds, Aquascape (via Atlantic Water Gardens), and Predatory Fins. Source: <https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>

VERIFIED (company background): New Jersey-based, founded 2008 (the origin story begins with a backyard pond built in summer 2005). Design/build/maintenance of ponds, waterfalls, and water features across NJ, PA, and TN. Describes itself as the top importer of Japanese koi in the USA; team travels to Japan three times a year to hand-select koi. Multiple retail locations (Green Brook, Fairfield, Colts Neck, Mount Holly — the Mount Holly location opened June 20) plus a Milford, NJ farm/warehouse HQ with six greenhouses. Carries Evolution Aqua, Bermuda, Atlantic, Oase. An "FFP Aquariums & Aquascaping" operation sits inside the Green Brook location. Sources: <https://fitzfishponds.com/> ; <https://fitzfishponds.com/our-locations/> ; <https://www.yelp.com/biz/fitzs-fish-ponds-green-brook> ; <https://www.yelp.com/biz/fitzs-fish-ponds-fairfield>

VERIFIED (bonus context for "local anchor" framing): Fitz's runs its own annual event, **Koi Fest**, at the Milford NJ farm — 2026 was the fifth edition, Aug 21–22, with a Tri-State ZNA Koi Show, a special-access facility tour day, a banquet, vendors, and free general admission. Sources: <https://fitzfishponds.com/blog/koi-fest-2026-returns-bigger-than-ever/> ; <https://www.njfamily.com/events/koi-fest/>

UNKNOWN: Exactly what Fitz's displayed at their NJ 2026 booth (koi, pond equipment, both).

I. Vanessa Glass

VERIFIED — she spoke, and here is the exact session.

Field	Detail
Name	Vanessa Glass
Affiliation as billed	Home Brew Live Feeds
Session title (exact)	The Coral Food Nutrition Pyramid
Stage / time	Speaker Stage, Sunday, September 13, 12:00pm

Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

⚠ **IMPORTANT CORRECTION TO YOUR NOTES:** Your working note describes her as speaking about "the science side of the hobby." The verified session is specifically about **coral nutrition on the reef/saltwater side** — feeding captive corals. Framing it as generic "hobby science" would be a misstatement of the billed topic. If your firsthand recollection is that the talk ranged wider than its title, say so as your own impression, not as the session description.

VERIFIED background/credentials:

- Described in CORAL Magazine as a reef industry professional with **Glass Aquatics / Home Brew Live Feeds**.
- **President of Glass Aquatics, LLC**, founded April 2001 — an aquarium service and retail company; the "about" page names Vanessa as the company's president.
- Home Brew Live Feeds is the product line built on Glass Aquatics' experience: small-batch live phytoplankton "coral cocktails"

with cocktail-themed product names — **Margarita** (core product), **Texas Tea**, and **Cosmopolitan** — infused with Hydrospace's **Purple Non-Sulfur Bacteria (PNSB)**.

- Based in **Hurst, Texas**.
- The Margarita product was **nominated for Best New Product at its debut at Aquashella Dallas 2024** — a direct Aquashella throughline.
- The brand uses a refill/"draft pour" dealer model at stores, with a \$2 cap-return credit.
- The company's own framing is a "Coral Nutrition Food Pyramid" — a structured feeding hierarchy rather than a single product.

Sources: <https://www.coralmagazine.com/2025/04/11/home-brew-live-feeds-an-introduction/> ; <https://www.glassaquatics.com/about-us/> ; <https://reefbuilders.com/2025/03/22/home-brew-live-feeds-combines-multiple-species-of-phyto-with-hydrospace-pnsb/> ; <https://premiumaquatics.com/collections/brand-home-brew-live-feeds> ; <https://www.saltwateraquarium.com/home-brew-live-feeds/>

VERIFIED (session content preview, from a sibling Aquashella listing): An Aquashella guest page describes the Home Brew talk as covering the core nutrients a captive reef needs, and why continuous feeding of those nutrients supports coral immune function, reduces oxidative stress, aids tissue repair, and improves coloration and growth. Source: <https://aquashella.com/dallas-guests/>

UNKNOWN: A formal speaker biography published by Aquashella for NJ 2026. Not found.

J. Aquascaping at NJ 2026

VERIFIED — display aquascapes / live aquascaping contest:

- The **Aquashella Aquascaping Contest (AAC)** ran at NJ 2026, with **Awards on the Speaker Stage Sunday at 11:00am**.
- Format per the official AAC page: selected contestants get **12 hours across two days** to build. Scaping is deliberately scheduled during show hours so attendees can watch and talk to the scapers while they work.
- Published build schedule: **Friday** 1:30pm contestant/judge kickoff, 2:00–6:00pm scaping, 6:00–7:00pm cleanup. **Saturday** 9:00am–5:00pm scaping, 5:00–6:00pm cleanup, **6:00pm judging begins**. **Sunday** 9:00am water changes and touch-ups for showcase day, **10:30am awards announced**, **3:00pm People's Choice Award announced**.
- Field is selected by Aquashella organizers from open applications; applications close 30 days out or when full. Contestants pay their own travel.
- **All finished scapes and equipment become Aquashella property and are sold by silent auction.** Sources: <https://aquashella.com/aac/> ; <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED — voting structure: There is a **People's Choice Award**, announced 3:00pm Sunday, in addition to judged placements. That is the official public-voting mechanism for the AAC. Source: <https://aquashella.com/aac/>

⚠ **UNKNOWN — voting mechanism details.** No official source states whether People's Choice voting at NJ 2026 used **QR codes**, paper ballots, an app, or something else. If you remember QR-code voting, that is **FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY** and should be attributed to you.

VERIFIED — speed scaping happened: The Feature Stage schedule lists **Speed Scaping Contest Round 1** (Sat 12:00pm), **Round 2** (Sat 2:00pm), **Round 3** (Sun 11:00am), and **Speed Scaping Championships** (Sun 12:00pm). Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

UNKNOWN — speed scaping format. No official Aquashella page publishes speed-scaping rules: no time limit, tank size, materials list, judging criteria, judge names, or competitor list could be found for NJ 2026. Do **not** state a time limit on air.

(For comparison only, and explicitly NOT Aquashella's rules: a differently-branded "Scaped" speed contest run by Nature Aquariums USA uses four contestants, 30 minutes, mystery-box materials, a 5-minute hardscape grab round, an audience-chosen mystery-object round, and a plant-shopping final. Useful for explaining the genre to listeners — label it clearly as a different event. Source: <https://natureaquariums.com/pages/scaped-contest>)

VERIFIED — masterclass component: **Daichi Araki**, ADA SUIKEI Creator, taught a three-part **Aquashella Aquascaping Masterclass** on the NJ Speaker Stage Saturday (presentation/substrate/hardscape at 11am and 12pm; planting at 2pm), using an **ADA W900mm full system**. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590>

VERIFIED — sponsors: Fluval (primary, per NJ contests page). Supporting sponsors listed: Aqua Natural, Betta Botanicals, West Coast Woodworks, Cherries Nature Aquarium, Sreepadma. The all-contests page instead credits Aqua Forest Aquarium x ADA as presenting. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://aquashella.com/contests/>.

UNKNOWN: AAC competitor names and judge names for NJ 2026. An Instagram post announcing a judging panel exists but was not retrievable in text form. Reference (not readable): https://www.instagram.com/p/DNGn6NkT_Z6/.

K. Livestock competitions at NJ 2026

Competition	Status	Evidence
Caridina shrimp	VERIFIED — The American Shrimp Contest ran at NJ 2026; registration opened August 2026 for the Sept 12–13 Edison show. Four of the seven contest categories are Caridina (Crystal; Taiwan Bee; Tiger variants; Tibee; Crossbreeds/eye morphs; Taitibee — six Caridina categories in total against one Neocaridina category)	https://reefs.com/shrimp-contest/ ; https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules ; https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Clownfish	VERIFIED as scheduled/listed on the official NJ 2026 contests page	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Guppy	VERIFIED as scheduled/listed on the official NJ 2026 contests page, and explicitly described as consumer-decided — the public picks best in show	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Stingray (USA Stingray Competition)	VERIFIED as listed for NJ 2026, with Predatory Fins, \$1,000 prize	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Koi	NOT listed on the NJ 2026 contests page (it is on the general all-contests page). The Fitz's koi <i>talk</i> was on the NJ schedule, but a koi <i>contest</i> was not	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/ ; https://aquashella.com/contests/
Frag Off (coral fragging)	VERIFIED as listed for NJ 2026	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Kids Aquascaping	VERIFIED as listed for NJ 2026	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/

Public voting — what's actually verified:

- **Guppy Contest: consumer-decided. VERIFIED.** Source: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/>
- **Aquascaping Contest: People's Choice Award. VERIFIED.** Source: <https://aquashella.com/aac/>
- **Guppy Contest (general Aquashella description): judged by expert judges AND a People's Choice Award, with a cash prize; every entry displayed in its own 5-gallon aquarium; judged on pattern, size, and unique features.** Source: <https://www.aquashella.com/aquashella-guppy-contest-entry/>
- **Shrimp Contest: judged, not public-voted.** Three judges per category, each awarding independent points; ties in the top three broken by the Lead Judge. Source: <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>

UNKNOWN: Whether QR-code voting or written ballots were used at NJ 2026 for any contest. **No source.** Treat as FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY.

UNKNOWN: Winners of any NJ 2026 contest. No results published yet as of this research date.

L. Reptiles at NJ 2026

VERIFIED (reptiles are a recurring, official Aquashella component): Reptiles are named in Aquashella's own event description and exhibitor pitch; an exhibitor calls it one of the biggest aquarium **and reptile** events in the country; and Aquashella runs a formal Vivarium Contest with standardized enclosures. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/> ; <https://aquashella.com/aquashella-vivarium-contest/>

VERIFIED (reptile-world presence on the NJ 2026 program):

- **Lori Barczyk**, CEO/Founder of **LegaSea Aquarium and The Reptarium**, spoke Saturday 4:30pm (*Building a Legacy*).
- **Dan The Turtle Man** is on the NJ 2026 Featured Guests list. Source: <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/>

VERIFIED (Barczyk / Reptarium background — strong human-interest thread): The Reptarium was founded by **Brian Barczyk**, a reptile educator and YouTuber with 5.72M subscribers, who died January 14, 2024 at 54. He did not live to see LegaSea Aquarium open; it opened **April 21, 2025**, a 30,000-square-foot facility in Utica, Michigan, and is now run by his wife **Lori Barczyk**, who also leads the Brian Barczyk YouTube channel. BHB Reptiles was co-founded by Brian and Lori in 1989. The combined facility houses giant snakes, lizards, freshwater and saltwater aquariums, stingrays, and mammals including a capybara, binturong, armadillo, and two-toed sloth. Sources: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brian_Barczyk ; <https://www.bhbreptiles.com/> ; <https://legaseaaquarium.com/> ; <https://www.thewildrx.com/2025/07/legasea-aquarium-the-reptarium-you-should-check-them-out/>

UNKNOWN: Which reptile vendors exhibited at NJ 2026, and which species were shown. No retrievable list.

UNKNOWN / FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY: A **large red tegu**. No source documents a red tegu at NJ 2026. Note for accuracy if you describe it: "red tegu" (*Salvator rufescens*) is a distinct species from the more commonly seen Argentine black-and-white tegu — worth being precise or saying you're describing it by appearance.

M. Mechanical shark

UNKNOWN — nothing found. No Aquashella page, press release, exhibitor announcement, or indexed social post documents a mechanical/animatronic shark as an official NJ 2026 attraction. Searches returned only animatronic-manufacturer catalogue pages with no Aquashella connection.

No price is documented anywhere. Do not state a price.

→ **FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY.** It works fine in audio as "there was a mechanical shark, which I did not expect" — but it should be voiced as your own account.

Adjacent verified context you can use instead: a 2023 third-party write-up of Aquashella noted that its aquarium displays run from small fish and shrimp up to larger animals like stingrays and sharks — so large-animal spectacle is part of the show's DNA, even though the mechanical shark itself is unconfirmed. Source: <https://naturalenvironmentaquatix.com/blogs/the-fish-tank-blog/aquashella-an-underwater-wonderland>

N. Pet Supplies Plus

VERIFIED (partner status): Pet Supplies Plus appears on Aquashella's official 2026 partner wall (logo file uploaded February 2026). Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

UNKNOWN: A specific NJ 2026 booth, booth number, swag/giveaway activity, or show promotion. Nothing located.

→ **Booth presence and swag = FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY**, supported by verified partner status.

O. All-in-one aquariums (10- and 20-gallon cubes under \$200)

PARTIALLY VERIFIED — but not at the sizes you noted.

VERIFIED: AQUATOP exhibited at **Booth 135**, and their headline products were three rear-chamber all-in-one systems: **AquaFin 5-Gallon (AQF-05)**, **AquaFin 8-Gallon (AQF-08)**, and **Ascension 9 (ASC-09)** — all running at the booth. The AquaFin 5 is described as curved panoramic glass with a rear filtration chamber concealing pump, bio media, and filter pad; the kit includes tank, filtration boxes, filter pad, bio media, pump, LED, and power components (heater sold separately). AquaFin models are 7.87"

deep; the 8-gallon needs 31.5" of width. Source: <https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/>

UNKNOWN: Any vendor at NJ 2026 selling **10- and 20-gallon cube-style rear-filtration AIO tanks under \$200**. No such vendor, brand, or pricing was located. AQUATOP's confirmed AIO lineup at the show was 5, 8, and 9 gallons — not 10 and 20.

→ **The 10/20-gallon cube AIOs under \$200 are FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY, and the vendor is unidentified.** If this detail matters to the episode, the honest framing is: "there was a booth selling cube-style all-in-ones in the 10-and-20-gallon range for under two hundred dollars, and I wish I'd written down who it was."

P. Used aquarium equipment booth ("the Facebook Marketplace booth")

UNKNOWN. No vendor, exhibitor listing, or post documents a used-equipment seller at NJ 2026.

Relevant structural note (VERIFIED, and it makes a used-gear booth entirely plausible): Aquashella's AAC rules state that all finished contest scapes **and equipment** become Aquashella property and are sold by **silent auction** — so secondhand gear does move at these shows through an official channel. That's a different thing from a general used-equipment vendor, though. Source: <https://aquashella.com/aac/>

→ **FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY.** The "Facebook Marketplace booth" line is yours and is genuinely good audio — just don't attach a vendor name you can't source.

SECTION 5 — THE FRESHWATER SIDE

5.1 What was verifiably on offer for freshwater keepers at NJ 2026

Category	Verified NJ 2026 item	Source
Aquascaping education	Daichi Araki (ADA SUIKEI Creator) three-part masterclass on an ADA W900mm full system: presentation, substrate, hardscape, planting	https://aquashella.com/ ; https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590
Paludarium / nano	DOOA mini-Paludarium display, DOOA Fully Automated System for Paludarium, and a hands-on DOOA Glass Pot SHIZUKU workshop, Sunday 1:30–3:00pm	https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590
All-in-one nano tanks	AQUATOP AquaFin 5, AquaFin 8, Ascension 9 — rear-chamber AIOs running live at Booth 135	https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/
Equipment breadth	AQUATOP also brought rimless high-clarity tanks, bow-front glass tanks, nano kits, filtration, lighting, heaters, pumps, accessories	https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/
Shrimp	American Shrimp Contest with seven judged categories (1 Neocaridina, 6 Caridina)	https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules
Shrimp vendors/sponsors	The Garden of Eder, Lucky Aquatics, AquaEL, Ultra Fresh Shrimp Delight listed as shrimp-contest supporting sponsors on the NJ page	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Plecos	Sabu Yamamoto, Saburai Aquatics — <i>What the L? An Introduction to Plecos</i> , Sat 3pm	https://aquashella.com/
Livebearers / hobby history	Phil Marraccini, formerly of Summerland Tropical Fish Farms — livebearer history, Sun 1:30pm	https://aquashella.com/
Breeding ethics	Jody Reed, Uncle Joe's Fish Shed — <i>Ethics and Best Management Practices for the Home Breeder</i> , Sun 12:45pm	https://aquashella.com/

Feeding science	Katrine, Kats Aquatics — <i>Foods and feeding your systems using science</i> , Sun 3pm	https://aquashella.com/
Natural/low-tech method	Lou Foxwell ("Father Fish") — <i>Natural Aquarium Methods</i> , Sun 2:15pm	https://aquashella.com/
Guppies	Guppy Contest, consumer-decided; general format displays each entry in its own 5-gallon tank, judged on pattern, size, unique features	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/ ; https://www.aquashella.com/aquashella-guppy-contest-entry/
Hardscape/botanicals	Betta Botanicals, West Coast Woodworks, Aqua Natural, Cherries Nature Aquarium, Sreepadma listed as aquascaping contest supporting sponsors	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Pond/koi crossover	Fitz's Fish Ponds competitive-koi session, Sat 1pm	https://aquashella.com/
Kids' freshwater entry point	Dustin's Fish Tanks—branded Kids Aquascaping Contest	https://aquashella.com/contests/

5.2 Pond/koi crossover — the strategic angle

VERIFIED: Mavrakis has articulated koi as the hobby's intersection point: he describes filming a client's reef tank and being taken outside to see their pond, or visiting a koi pond and learning the homeowner also has a reef tank in their office. 2025 brought in more koi and pond vendors than any prior year, and Dallas hosted a koi show. Source: <https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>

This is one of the most quotable strategic ideas in the whole research set, and it's on the record from the founder.

5.3 Standout species / trends

UNKNOWN — deliberately left empty. No corpus of NJ 2026 photos or videos was available to identify species trends without generalizing from thin evidence. Specifically:

- **Angelfish prevalence: FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY.** No external source documents an angelfish-heavy NJ 2026 floor.
- The only species-adjacent trends verifiable from the *program* (not the floor) are: **plecos** (dedicated talk), **livebearers/guppies** (talk + contest), **Caridina shrimp** (six of seven contest categories), **koi**, **designer clownfish**, and **stingrays**.

SECTION 6 — THE SALTWATER / REEF SIDE

6.1 What's verified for NJ 2026

Item	Status	Source
Clownfish Contest — designer varieties, bold patterns, rare morphs	VERIFIED as listed for NJ 2026	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Frag Off — live coral fragging/propagation on the Feature Stage, judged on both speed of fragging technique and artistry of arrangement	VERIFIED as listed for NJ 2026	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/
Saltwater Jeopardy — Feature Stage, Sunday 3:00pm	VERIFIED	https://aquashella.com/
Coral nutrition talk — Vanessa Glass, Home Brew Live Feeds, Sunday 12:00pm	VERIFIED	https://aquashella.com/
Reef-side featured guests — Polo Reef, The Reef Vet, Reefer_NYC, Bella's Seahorse Beauties, George Mavrakis (CoralFish12g), Octo Nation	VERIFIED as listed guests	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/
	VERIFIED as	

Reef-adjacent partner brands (2026 season) — Tropic Marin, Chemi-Pure, Deltec/RAD/JFA, AquaFX, CaribSea, Lifegard	partners , not as NJ booths	https://aquashella.com/
Stingrays — USA Stingray Competition with Predatory Fins (note: stingrays here are the freshwater/exotic side, via Predatory Fins)	VERIFIED as listed	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/

6.2 Coral vendor list for NJ 2026

UNKNOWN. No retrievable coral vendor list for NJ 2026. For 2025, a community video titled as covering every saltwater vendor at Aquashella New Jersey exists (ReefnBid), but the vendor names were not extractable. Reference:

<https://www.manhattanreefs.com/forum/general-discussion/309114-video-every-saltwater-vendor-aquashella-new-jersey-reefnbid-1.html>

6.3 Blue-light presentation — the science, beginner-friendly and accurate

Visually distinct blue-lit reef section: FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY as an NJ 2026 layout fact. But *why* reef sections look blue is well-documented and safe to explain on air.

Three separate, mutually reinforcing reasons — all VERIFIED:

1. Water filters out long wavelengths first. Seawater attenuates light unevenly by wavelength. Reds and oranges drop out within the first few metres; blue penetrates deepest. A coral living at depth has evolved under a light field that is overwhelmingly blue. Reef aquarists reproduce that light field rather than a terrestrial one. Sources: <https://www.reef2reef.com/ams/the-optimal-light-spectrum-in-a-reef-aquarium.809/> ; <https://reefcoaquariums.com/blogs/news/what-makes-corals-glow>

2. Blue is where the coral's symbiotic algae actually absorb. Most reef-building corals depend on symbiotic dinoflagellates (zooxanthellae, genus *Symbiodinium*) living inside their tissue. These algae photosynthesise and can supply up to roughly **90%** of the coral's energy. Their pigments — chlorophyll a plus carotenoids including peridinin — absorb strongly in the violet/blue range, with the **420–470 nm** band described as the primary absorption peak. That's why reef tanks look blue: the spectrum is tuned to what the symbionts use, not to what looks natural to a human eye. Sources: <https://allcorals.com/guides/reef-lighting> ; <https://www.reef2reef.com/ams/the-optimal-light-spectrum-in-a-reef-aquarium.809/> ; <https://www.recifart.com/en/blog-recifart/reef-aquarium/do-corals-prefer-white-or-blue-light>

3. Blue light triggers fluorescence — the glow. Corals contain **fluorescent proteins** that absorb short-wavelength light (blue and UV) and re-emit it at longer wavelengths, producing the greens, oranges, and pinks that make a reef display pop. In nature these proteins appear to function partly as a biological sunscreen and partly as antioxidant protection against free radicals generated during photosynthesis; research has also shown photoconvertible red fluorescent proteins can transform blue light into orange-red that penetrates deeper into coral tissue, helping symbionts shaded beneath the surface layer. Sources: <https://reefcoaquariums.com/blogs/news/what-makes-corals-glow> ; <https://allcorals.com/guides/reef-lighting> ; <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC5524488/>

Peer-reviewed support for the growth claim: A controlled LED study on *Goniopora columna* found blue (440–470 nm) and purple (400–430 nm) light increased protease activity and body protein and improved growth and survival, concluding 400–470 nm is suitable as the primary illumination for that coral. Source: <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8833557/>

Important nuance — do not oversimplify: Blue-only is not automatically "best." Most corals perform better over time under a broader spectrum; white light complements blue by widening the spectrum and making fish colours read naturally to the eye. Intense red light is associated with oxidative stress in corals and tends to favour nuisance algae. And cameras exaggerate blue-light fluorescence relative to what the eye actually sees — which is worth saying on air, because it explains why reef photos online look more electric than a reef tank in your living room. Sources: <https://allcorals.com/guides/reef-lighting> ; <https://www.reef2reef.com/ams/the-optimal-light-spectrum-in-a-reef-aquarium.809/> ; <https://ocdreefs.com/blue-vs-white-light-saltwater-aquarium/>

Honest framing for a freshwater-leaning show: the practical reason a convention reef section is blue-lit is a *stack* of reasons — it's what the corals' symbionts use, it's what makes the fluorescent proteins fire, and it happens to be spectacular under aisle lighting. The aesthetic and the biology point the same direction, which is not always true in this hobby.

SECTION 7 — SHRIMP AND INVERTEBRATES

7.1 AQUASHELLA NEW JERSEY 2026 — VERIFIED CONTEST RULES

These come from the American Shrimp Contest's own published rules and Aquashella's own entry page. **Caveat noted below.**

Verified categories (7):

1. **Neocaridina** — all types, all colours (e.g. Red Cherry, Orange Rili, Blue Dream)
2. **Caridina Crystal** — all colours and grades (Crystal Red, Super Black Crystal, Pure Red Line)
3. **Caridina Taiwan Bee** — all colours and grades (Blue Bolt, Red King Kong, Black Panda)
4. **Caridina Tiger variants** — all colours and patterns (Orange Eye Blue Tiger, Red Tiger, Black Tiger Orange Eye)
5. **Caridina Tibee** — all colours and patterns (Fancy Red Tiger, Fancy Black Tiger)
6. **Caridina Crossbreeds** — all colours and patterns, eye morphs (Orange Eye Yellow King Kong, Hallow Eye Red Ghost, Orange Eye Red Devil)
7. **Caridina Taitibee** — all colours and patterns (Galaxy Pinto, Nanshi, Boa)

Verified entry and group rules:

- **US hobbyists only**, showing shrimp they bred and raised themselves; registration is an affirmation of that. Reasonable doubt means disqualification with no refund.
- **Entry fee \$25 per group**; maximum **2 sets per category** per participant.
- **Group = 3 to 5 shrimp**. If more than 3, the best 3 are judged. More than 5 = disqualification.
- **Minimum size ¾ inch**.
- **No wild-type shrimp**.
- Visible parasite infestation disqualifies the entire group, at the Lead Judge's determination.
- Berried shrimp that release offspring during the contest: the participant is responsible for catching them afterward.
- **Maximum 100 show tanks**, first come first served; registration can close early if filled.

Verified judging:

- Judges are appointed by the organising committee and **cannot enter** — nor can their family members.
- The best three invertebrates in a group are compared by judges using a **points system**, with assessment guidelines specific to each group's characteristics.
- **Three judges per category**, each awarding their own points. Ties in the top three are broken by the **Lead Judge**.
- After judging, each tank is labelled with category, breeder name, and points awarded.

Verified show-tank standardisation (this is a great detail for audio):

- Water parameters maintained within acceptable limits **per category**.
- Suitable substrate used for every category.
- Lighting: integrated or mounted strip light.
- Filter: air-driven sponge filter or motor filter.
- **Water: RO water with a shrimp-specific remineraliser**.
- Tanks numbered/tagged consecutively.

Verified logistics:

- Contest tanks must be ready by **5pm Friday**; winners announced **Sunday at 2pm**; prizes distributed then.
- Shipped entries accepted; each group bagged separately, bag marked with category, genus, and variant in waterproof marker, **no name on the bag** (name and address outside the package or on an enclosed letter).
- Uncollected shrimp become the organising committee's property, are auctioned, and proceeds fund future shows.
- Pickup in person Sunday **between 5pm and 6pm**, or by an authorised person with written authorisation and photo ID.
- Liability excluded for losses, illness, or failure during transport or exhibition; a daily loss list is tracked and available on request.

Sources: <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules> ; <https://aquashella.com/aquashella-shrimp-contest-entry/>

⚠ **CAVEAT YOU MUST RESPECT:** The public rules page still carries **Daytona 2024 dates and a Daytona shipping address** (Ocean Center, 101 N Atlantic Ave, Daytona Beach FL, with an October 30 2024 shipment window and a November 3 2024 award time). The *structural* rules — categories, group size, minimum size, judge count, tank spec, RO water — read as the standing framework. The *dates, deadlines, addresses, and the \$250 overall prize figure* are demonstrably event-specific and stale. **State the structural rules as the contest's rules; do not state the \$250 figure or the Sunday-2pm award time as NJ 2026 facts without further confirmation.**

Verified NJ 2026-specific: Registration for the NJ 2026 American Shrimp Contest opened in August 2026 for the Sept 12–13 Edison show, sponsored by Hikari per that announcement. Source: <https://reefs.com/shrimp-contest/>

Verified contest mission statement: The stated purpose is to give **US** shrimp breeders a platform to compete for a national title **without facing global-level competition** — i.e. it is deliberately scoped to the domestic breeding scene. Sources: <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>

7.2 GENERAL SHRIMP-COMPETITION CONTEXT — *clearly separate from the above*

This section is general background about competitive shrimp breeding. **It is NOT Aquashella's rulebook.** Do not present these as Aquashella criteria on air.

Caridina vs Neocaridina — the fundamentals (VERIFIED, taxonomic/biological):

- **Neocaridina** is a genus of small land-locked freshwater shrimp in the family Atyidae, native to East Asia, with roughly 25–30 described species depending on treatment. The genus was established by I. Kubo in 1938; type species *Neocaridina denticulata*. Source: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neocaridina>
- **Neocaridina davidi** — the "cherry shrimp" — is native to Taiwan, eastern China, the Korean Peninsula, and Vietnam. Wild type is a mottled brown; selective breeding has produced red, orange, yellow, green, blue, violet, white, clear and more. They have **no distinct larval stage**, reach maturity in about **30 days**, live roughly **1–2 years**, and reach about **3–4 cm** at maturity. They tolerate a wide range of conditions and have become invasive in thermally polluted waterways in Japan, the US, Poland, and Germany, likely via released captive stock. Source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neocaridina_davidi
- **Caridina** lines (Crystal, Taiwan Bee, Tiger, Tibee, Taitibee, crossbreeds) are generally regarded in the hobby as more demanding on water chemistry and more genetically involved to fix. The Aquashella category structure itself reflects that: one Neocaridina bucket versus six Caridina buckets.

What judges/breeders generally look for (GENERAL CONTEXT — not Aquashella-verified): Competitive shrimp judging across the international shrimp-contest tradition typically assesses colour depth and saturation, colour coverage and opacity, pattern clarity and symmetry, consistency across the group (which is why a group is judged, not an individual), size and body condition, and absence of defects or parasites. Aquashella's published rules confirm **only** the following as its actual mechanics: a points system, category-specific assessment guidelines, three judges, best-three-of-group comparison, minimum size, no wild type, and parasite disqualification. Everything beyond that list is genre context, not Aquashella rule.

Why competition shrimp look different from pet-store shrimp — the honest explanation: the rule that entries must be **home-bred by the entrant**, combined with judging the **best three of a group** rather than a single standout individual, rewards *consistency across a line* rather than one lucky animal. That is what selective breeding actually is — and it's the difference between a tank of mixed-grade cherries and a line where every animal looks the same. Source for the rules underpinning this: <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>

Blue Diamond Neocaridina: a fixed blue colour morph of *Neocaridina davidi*. **UNKNOWN** whether any specific NJ 2026 vendor sold them.

SECTION 8 — AQUASCAPING

8.1 Verified NJ 2026 aquascaping content

Covered in detail in **Section 4J**. Summary of what's verified:

- **AAC (Aquashella Aquascaping Contest)**: 12 hours across two days, organiser-selected field, open application, live on the show floor during public hours, judged Saturday 6pm, awards Sunday 10:30/11:00am, **People's Choice announced Sunday 3pm**, all finished scapes and equipment sold by **silent auction**.
- **Speed Scaping**: Rounds 1–3 plus Championships on the Feature Stage. **Format, time limits, judges, and competitors: UNKNOWN**.
- **ADA Masterclass** with Daichi Araki on a W900mm full system, split into presentation/substrate/hardscape and planting blocks.
- **DOOA Glass Pot SHIZUKU workshop**, Sunday 1:30–3:00pm on the Feature Stage, pre-registered via Aqua Forest Aquarium.
- **Sponsors**: Fluval primary; supporting — Aqua Natural, Betta Botanicals, West Coast Woodworks, Cherries Nature Aquarium, Sreepadma. (Conflicting attribution to Aqua Forest Aquarium × ADA on the general contests page.)

Sources: <https://aquashella.com/aac/> ; <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590>

PERSONAL/COMMUNITY OBSERVATION: On the ScapeCrunch forum, attendees planning for the Jersey show discussed Araki's Saturday masterclass and the SHIZUKU workshop as the main draws, and one poster recommended going **day one and early** if you intend to buy fish, shrimp, or plants, and going later if you're there for workshops and conversation. Also mentioned: aquascaper **Juris Jutjajevs** had announced he would attend the Jersey show (announcement itself not independently verified). Source: <https://scapecrunch.com/threads/aquashella-2026-edison-nj.3322/>

8.2 Why timed aquascaping is creatively useful — research-grounded, not motivational

Framing this as supporting context rather than inspiration, as requested.

The mechanism, stated plainly: a hard time limit removes the option of iterating indefinitely. In a 12-hour AAC build, the scaper still has room to revise. In a speed round, they don't. What the clock does is force **commitment to an early structural decision** — where the focal point sits, where the negative space goes, which way the visual flow runs — and then force execution against that decision rather than relitigation of it.

Why that maps onto aquascaping specifically: aquascaping judging criteria in the established contest tradition weigh compositional fundamentals heavily — balance between components, effective use of space, whether open areas balance enclosed ones. The AGA's published guidelines, for instance, explicitly ask whether balance exists between the various components and whether space is used effectively, with open areas complementing more enclosed ones. These are **structural** judgements, largely settled in the first arrangement of hardscape, not rescued later by plant selection. Source: <https://showcase.aquatic-gardeners.org/guidelines.html>

The honest limitation: timed work optimises for decisiveness and legible composition. It does not optimise for the things a long-horizon scape is actually judged on in a home tank — plant health over months, growth-in, maintenance realism, or biological stability. A speed scape is a composition exercise performed in an aquarium, which is a different craft from building an aquarium that will still look good in a year. Both are worth watching; they are not the same skill.

The one thing timed scaping genuinely demonstrates to an audience: that hardscape placement, not plant shopping, is where a scape is won or lost. Watching someone commit to a rock layout in a few minutes and then build everything else around it makes that visible in a way a finished-tank photo never does.

SECTION 9 — SPEAKERS AND EDUCATION

9.1 Full verified NJ 2026 speaker list

All from <https://aquashella.com/> (New Jersey Event Schedule), unless otherwise noted.

#	Speaker	Role / affiliation	Session title	Day / time	Credentials & notes
1	Gettin' Fishy With It Podcast	Aquarium science podcast	<i>Fishin' For Knowledge: Our Favorite Fish in Science</i>	Sat 10:30am	No further credentials verified
2	Daichi Araki	ADA SUIKEI Creator , Aqua Design Amano	Aquashella Aquascaping Masterclass (3 blocks: presentation/substrate/hardscape, then planting)	Sat 11am, 12pm, 2pm	Taught on an ADA W900mm full system ; booth 223 with US distributor Aqua Forest Aquarium. Note: ADA's release lists 10:30am; Aquashella lists 11:00am. Source: https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590
3	Fitz's Fish Ponds	NJ pond/koi builder and Japanese koi importer	<i>What are Competitive Koi? Learn What it Takes to Win</i>	Sat 1:00pm	Founded 2008; multiple NJ retail locations plus a Milford farm with six greenhouses; team travels to Japan three times yearly to select koi; runs its own Koi Fest with a Tri-State ZNA koi show. Sources: https://fitzfishponds.com/ ; https://fitzfishponds.com/our-locations/ ; https://fitzfishponds.com/blog/koi-fest-2026-returns-bigger-than-ever/
4	Sabu Yamamoto	Saburai Aquatics	<i>What the L? An Introduction to Plecos</i>	Sat 3:00pm	No further credentials verified
5	Pet Advocacy Network + USAqua	Industry advocacy organisations	Panel: <i>Current Pressures on the Aquarium Trade</i>	Sat 3:45pm	Policy/trade panel — the most "state of the hobby" item on the program
6	Lori Barczyk	CEO/Founder, LegaSea Aquarium and The Reptarium	<i>Building a Legacy</i>	Sat 4:30pm	Co-founded BHB Reptiles with Brian Barczyk in 1989; now leads the Brian Barczyk YouTube channel; LegaSea opened April 21 2025, a 30,000 sq ft Utica MI facility Brian did not live to see open. Sources: https://www.bhbreptiles.com/ ; https://legaseaaquarium.com/ ; https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brian_Barczyk
7	Vanessa Glass	Home Brew Live Feeds / Glass Aquatics	<i>The Coral Food Nutrition Pyramid</i>	Sun 12:00pm	President of Glass Aquatics LLC (founded April 2001), Hurst TX. HBLF makes small-batch live phytoplankton "coral cocktails" (Margarita, Texas Tea, Cosmopolitan) infused with Hydrospace PNSB. Margarita was nominated Best New Product at its Aquashella Dallas 2024 debut . Sources: https://www.coralmagazine.com/2025/04/11/home-brew-live-feeds-an-introduction/ ; https://www.glassaquatics.com/about-us/ ; https://reefbuilders.com/2025/03/22/home-brew-live-feeds-combines-multiple-species-of-phyto-with-hydrospace-pnsb/
8	Jody Reed	Uncle Joe's Fish Shed	<i>Ethics and Best Management Practices for the Home Breeder</i>	Sun 12:45pm	No further credentials verified
9	Phil Marraccini	Formerly of Summerland Tropical Fish	<i>History & Development of the Tropical Fish Hobby — Livebearers!</i>	Sun 1:30pm	Billed by his former farm affiliation — the hobby-history slot

		Farms			
10	Lou "Father Fish" Foxwell (billed by Aquashella as "Maxwell" — see 4B)	Father Fish Aquarium	<i>Natural Aquarium Methods</i>	Sun 2:15pm	70+ years in fishkeeping; developed the Father Fish Method (deep substrate: soil under ~3" sand, heavy easy-plant load, no CO ₂ , no chemical ferts); founding board member of the National Aquarium in Baltimore; store now in Salisbury MD. Sources: https://fatherfishaquarium.com/about-us/ ; https://father-fish-aquarium.myshopify.com/pages/about-us ; https://aquariumscience.org/15-17-father-fish-aquariums/
11	Katrine	Kats Aquatics	<i>Foods and feeding your systems using science</i>	Sun 3:00pm	Also listed as a featured guest (KatsAquatics)

Also on stage but not a lecture: Diverman (Diverman Jeopardy, Diverman Show — Live Interviews, Diverman Show and Tell) — a recurring Feature Stage personality across Saturday and Sunday.

9.2 Educational themes across the NJ 2026 program

Mapped from the verified session list:

Theme	Sessions that carry it
Fishkeeping science / general biology	Gettin' Fishy With It; Kats Aquatics feeding-science talk
Nutrition and feeding	Vanessa Glass (coral); Kats Aquatics (systems generally)
Aquascaping technique	Araki masterclass (3 blocks); SHIZUKU paludarium workshop; AAC; Speed Scaping
Reefkeeping	Vanessa Glass; Saltwater Jeopardy; Frag Off; Clownfish Contest
Breeding and husbandry ethics	Jody Reed, home-breeder ethics and best management practices
Species deep-dives	Plecocos (Yamamoto); livebearers (Marraccini); competitive koi (Fitz's)
Natural / low-tech method	Father Fish, natural aquarium methods
Hobby history	Marraccini on the development of the tropical fish hobby
Trade policy / conservation pressure	Pet Advocacy Network + USAqua panel
Business / legacy	Lori Barczyk, <i>Building a Legacy</i>
Shrimp keeping	Contest-adjacent rather than lecture-based at NJ 2026
Plant care	Embedded in the Araki masterclass planting block rather than standalone
Equipment	Vendor-floor rather than stage at NJ 2026 (unlike Orlando 2026, which had a dedicated ReefBrite lighting talk)

Notable observation for the episode: there was **no standalone water-chemistry lecture** on the NJ 2026 Speaker Stage. The chemistry content that existed was embedded — in Father Fish's substrate method, in the shrimp contest's RO-plus-remineraliser tank standard, in the feeding-science talk. That's a real structural point about what a festival-format show prioritises versus what a club-meeting circuit prioritises.

SECTION 10 — BRANDS, VENDORS, AND COMMERCE

Standing caveat: no complete NJ 2026 exhibitor list exists in retrievable form. The table below combines (a) booth-confirmed NJ 2026 exhibitors, (b) 2026-season Aquashella partners, and (c) contest sponsors named on the NJ page. Each row is labelled.

10.1 Categorised exhibitor/brand table

Category	Brand	Evidence tier	What they're known for / what they highlighted
Equipment manufacturer (AIO tanks)	AQUATOP	NJ 2026 booth-confirmed (Booth 135)	Aquariums, kits, filtration, lighting, heaters, pumps. Highlighted three new rear-chamber all-in-one desktop systems: AquaFin 5 (AQF-05), AquaFin 8 (AQF-08), Ascension 9 (ASC-09) — all running live. Also brought rimless high-clarity and bow-front tanks, nano kits, Pisces 25W preset heater
Aquascaping system / hardscape / substrate	ADA (Aqua Design Amano) with Aqua Forest Aquarium	NJ 2026 booth-confirmed (Booth 223)	The originator of the Nature Aquarium style. Displayed a full ADA-system Nature Aquarium plus DOOA mini-Paludarium and DOOA Fully Automated System; ran the Araki masterclass and the DOOA Glass Pot SHIZUKU workshop
Filtration / equipment / stage sponsor	Fluval	2026 partner + NJ contest sponsor	Mass-market filtration, lighting, and tanks. Sponsors the Aquashella Aquascaping Contest, the Kids Aquascaping Contest area, and mainstage/feature stage
Food	Hikari	2026 partner; NJ shrimp contest sponsor per reefs.com	One of the most recognisable fish-food brands in the hobby. Long-standing Aquashella partner (logo on the wall since at least 2023)
Pet retail chain	Pet Supplies Plus	2026 partner	National pet retail chain; partner-wall logo added Feb 2026
Salt / water chemistry	Tropic Marin	2026 partner	Premium synthetic sea salt and reef additives
Chemical filtration	Chemi-Pure	2026 partner	Chemical filtration media, a long-standing reef staple
Water treatment / RO	AquaFX	2026 partner	RO/DI systems and filtration for aquarium water prep
Substrate	CaribSea	2026 partner	Aquarium sands, gravels, and live substrates
Equipment	Lifegard Aquatics	2026 partner	Tanks, filtration, plumbing, UV
Reef equipment	Deltec / RAD / JFA	2026 partner	Skimmers and reef equipment
Reptile enclosures	Custom Cages	2026 partner	Reptile/exotics enclosures
Livestock marketplace	Palm Street	2026 partner	Live-selling livestock marketplace platform
Equipment	Nu Aqua, Studio Aquatica, Aqua Natural	2026 partners	Aqua Natural also a named AAC supporting sponsor

Shrimp breeder	The Garden of Eder	NJ contest sponsor + Grant Eder is an NJ featured guest	140+ varieties of dwarf freshwater shrimp across 400+ aquariums, Weeki Wachee FL. Effectively administers the American Shrimp Contest
Shrimp	Lucky Aquatics, Ultra Fresh Shrimp Delight, AquaEL, Dymax	NJ shrimp contest sponsors (per NJ contests page)	Shrimp-sector vendors, foods, and equipment
Botanicals / hardscape	Betta Botanicals, West Coast Woodworks, Cherries Nature Aquarium, Sreepadma	NJ AAC supporting sponsors	Leaf litter/botanicals, hardscape wood, aquascaping supply
Pond / koi	Fitz's Fish Ponds	NJ 2026 speaker-confirmed; NJ 2025 vendor-confirmed	NJ's leading pond builder and a major Japanese koi importer
Pond / koi (2025 NJ, not re-verified for 2026)	RNR Koi, Poly Tank, Aqua Meds, Aquascape (via Atlantic Water Gardens)	NJ 2025 only	Named by POND Trade for the 2025 Edison show
Exotic fish / stingrays	Predatory Fins	NJ 2026 featured guest; USA Stingray Competition partner	Monster-fish and stingray specialist
Terrarium/vivarium	Vision Racks & Cages	Vivarium contest equipment provider	Model 322 75-gallon enclosure used as the standard contest enclosure

Sources for the above: <https://aquashella.com/> ; <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/> ; <https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/> ; <https://aquashella.com/aquashella-vivarium-contest/> ; <https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/> ; <https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590> ; <https://reefs.com/shrimp-contest/> ; <https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>

10.2 Categories with no verified NJ 2026 representation

Listed honestly so you don't imply coverage that isn't sourced: **coral vendors** (none named), **fish breeders** (none named beyond the contest/speaker context), **plant vendors** (none named), **local fish stores** (none named), **art/merchandise vendors** (none named beyond the official Aquashella Merch Booth), **used equipment** (none named), **food concessions** (none documented).

SECTION 11 — COMMUNITY AND CULTURE

Everything in this section is labelled by source type. There is no consensus to report — the community is genuinely split on Aquashella, and that split is more interesting than a manufactured "everyone loved it."

11.1 What the organisers say the culture is

VERIFIED (official positioning): The event pitches itself as a place where expert hobbyists, first-time visitors, families, and kids all coexist, and where people come to explore, be inspired, and share a love of everything aquatic. Creator interaction is an explicit product feature — live streams, Q&A, photo opportunities with "your favorite star." Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

VERIFIED (founder's stated thesis): Mavrakis's framing is that the corners of the hobby overlap far more than people realise — the reef keeper with a koi pond, the pond owner with an office reef — and that the show exists to connect them. Source: <https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>

11.2 What attendees actually said (PERSONAL/COMMUNITY OBSERVATION — do not present as fact)

Positive / practical:

- ScapeCrunch members planning the 2026 Jersey show treated it as worth travelling for, specifically for the ADA masterclass and SHIZUKU workshop, and at least one member arranged weekend coverage at work to attend. Practical advice shared among them: **go day one and early if you want to buy livestock or plants; go later if you're there for workshops and conversation.** Source: <https://scapecrunch.com/threads/aquashella-2026-edison-nj.3322/>
- A regional reef-forum member noted that having both freshwater and saltwater under one roof is "always interesting," framing the crossover as a draw. Source: <https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/>
- A third-party retailer blog advised arriving early for rare fish or coral because many vendors operate first-come-first-served, and bringing a cooler or insulated bag for livestock transport. Source: <https://shop.ageofaquariums.biz/blogs/news/aquashella-2025>

Critical (2025 NJ show, same venue):

- Day-one entry was described as chaotic: the ticketing website not working, forcing a more expensive purchase; long lines; scanner problems. One member posted live from the queue that the operation wasn't handling the crowd.
- The same member said mixing salt, fresh, and reptile into one expo produced dense crowds of people browsing and talking rather than moving, and said they would not attend again.
- Reef-specific quality was rated below Reefapalooza by that attendee.
- Ticket pricing drew complaints, with one member saying shows had become overpriced and opting out at \$30 presale / \$37 door. Source (all of the above): <https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/>

Note on how to use this: these are 2025 observations from a reef-focused club forum — an audience predisposed to compare Aquashella unfavourably to a reef-only convention. That doesn't make the complaints invalid; it does mean they represent one constituency's view, not the room's.

11.3 Recurring cultural themes that are actually supported

Theme	Support level
Meeting online creators in person	VERIFIED as a designed feature — 22 featured guests, VIP meet & greets scheduled twice daily, a Featured Creator application process, and "YouTube meet & greet" listed as a VIP ticket benefit. Source: https://aquashella.com/ ; https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/
Freshwater and saltwater under	VERIFIED as founding design intent since 2018's 40/40 vendor split. Source: reefbuilders 2018

one roof	
Beginners alongside experienced hobbyists	VERIFIED as stated intent — "entry level to advanced" speaker programming, explicit welcome to first-time visitors. Source: https://aquashella.com/
Families and kids	VERIFIED — Kids Zone, Mermaid Cove, kids aquascaping contest, kids ticket tier, free under 4
Buying livestock in person	VERIFIED as an economic feature — VIP tier explicitly sold "first pick" of livestock as a benefit as far back as 2018. Source: reefbuilders 2018
Seeing equipment before buying	VERIFIED via exhibitor framing — AQUATOP explicitly pitched the show as a chance to see gear in person and talk to the people who build it, with all three new AIOs running live. Source: aquatop.com
Aquascaping inspiration	VERIFIED — live scaping during public hours is a deliberate design choice per the AAC page
Crowding as a downside of the crossover	PERSONAL/COMMUNITY OBSERVATION — one 2025 attendee
Sense of belonging	FIRSTHAND OBSERVATION ONLY — your own experience. No external source measures this, and none could

SECTION 12 — WHY AQUARIUM CONVENTIONS MATTER

Balanced context. Where a claim is grounded in something verified about Aquashella specifically, the source is given; otherwise it's labelled as general reasoning.

12.1 Benefits

Community building. (*Grounded*) The hobby is largely solitary and largely online. Aquashella's structure — 22 featured guests, scheduled meet & greets, two speaker stages, a kids zone — is built entirely around converting an online audience into a physical one for two days. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

Education at scale, free with admission. (*Grounded*) Eleven distinct speaker sessions across two days at NJ 2026, spanning plecos, livebearers, koi, coral nutrition, breeding ethics, trade policy, and natural-method fishkeeping — all included in a \$25–\$85 ticket. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

Breeders reaching customers directly. (*Grounded*) The American Shrimp Contest requires entrants to have bred their own shrimp, and gives them 100 numbered, labelled tanks in front of thousands of attendees. That is a credential-building mechanism for small breeders that doesn't exist online. Source: <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>

Local and independent businesses getting a national floor. (*Grounded*) Fitz's Fish Ponds — a New Jersey pond contractor — got a main-stage speaking slot at a national touring show in its home state. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

Major brands demonstrating products. (*Grounded*) AQUATOP set up all three new all-in-one systems running live rather than boxed on a shelf. That's a product demonstration you cannot replicate from a product page. Source: <https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/>

Seeing livestock before purchase. (*General reasoning*) Colour, finnage, body condition, activity, and — crucially — how an animal actually behaves are all things a photo or a live-sale stream renders imperfectly. Buying in person is the only way to apply your own judgement before money changes hands.

Reducing live-animal shipping. (*Partly grounded*) Shipping is the highest-risk phase of livestock commerce. Aquashella's own shrimp-contest rules exclude liability for losses, illness, or failure **during transportation**, and require a tracked daily loss list — an implicit acknowledgement that transport is where things go wrong. Buying at the show removes one shipping leg entirely. Note the

counterweight in 12.2. Source: <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>

Exposure to unfamiliar sides of the hobby. (*Grounded*) The fresh/salt/reptile/koi mix means a freshwater keeper walks past a blue-lit reef section and a vivarium build whether they planned to or not. That's the design. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

Networking and creator/audience interaction. (*Grounded*) Scheduled twice-daily meet & greets, live streams, and Q&A. Source: <https://aquashella.com/>

12.2 Limitations — stated as balance, not warning

Crowds. (*Grounded in community observation*) At least one 2025 NJ attendee described dense browsing crowds and entry-line problems. Staged hourly entry exists precisely because crowd flow is a known constraint. Sources: <https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/> ; <https://aquashella.com/>

Impulse purchases. (*General reasoning*) A convention floor is optimised for decision-making under time pressure, surrounded by people making the same decision. The VIP tier is literally sold on getting first pick. That's a good deal and also a structural nudge toward buying faster than you'd buy at home.

Livestock transport stress. (*Grounded*) Retailer guidance for this show advises bringing a cooler or insulated bag, which implies a real bagged-animal journey home at the end of a long day in a convention hall. Temperature swings and a long day in a bag are real variables. Source: <https://shop.ageofaquariums.biz/blogs/news/aquashella-2025>

Temporary display conditions. (*Grounded*) Contest shrimp live in standardised temporary tanks for a weekend, with a tracked daily loss list. Display animals at any convention are in a short-term setup, not their long-term home — which is fine, and also means a display tank is not evidence of how that animal will look in month six. Source: <https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>

Convention pricing is not automatically cheaper. (*Grounded in community observation*) A 2025 attendee weighed \$30 presale / \$37 door admission against the value of going at all. Admission is a real cost that has to be amortised across whatever you buy. Separately, another regional-show attendee described Sunday as offering better deals but thinner selection — a genuine trade-off, not a hack. Sources: <https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/> ; <https://reefs.com/forum/general-discussion/310731-reef-palooza-2026-around-corner-aquashella-september-1.html>

Hard to evaluate equipment quickly. (*General reasoning*) A running demo on a show floor tells you the pump is quiet in a room that isn't quiet, that the tank looks good under booth lighting, and that the rep is knowledgeable. It doesn't tell you about long-term reliability, parts availability, or how the thing behaves in month eighteen.

SECTION 13 — PODCAST-WORTHY STORY ANGLES (RANKED)

Angles, not titles. Ranked by a combination of (a) how much verified material supports them, (b) how much your firsthand experience adds that research can't, and (c) how well they suit a freshwater-leaning, beginner-to-intermediate audience.

Tier 1 — strongest

1. A hobby that's usually solitary, in a room with seven thousand other people. The strongest angle, because it's the one only a firsthand account can carry. Support: NJ 2025 drew 7,000+ (POND Trade). The whole show design — meet & greets, kids zone, two stages — is an infrastructure for turning an online audience physical. Your "sense of belonging" observation is the payoff, and it's honestly yours to claim.

2. The founder's actual thesis: all roads lead to koi. Mavrakis's own quote about filming a reef tank and being taken outside to see the client's pond is the best single idea in the research. It reframes the show from "expo with a lot of stuff" to "argument that the hobby's silos are fake." Fully sourced, quotable, and it justifies the fresh/salt/reptile/koi mix instead of just describing it.

3. Six Caridina categories and one Neocaridina category — what a contest structure reveals about selective breeding. Concrete, verifiable, and genuinely educational. The category list itself is the argument: the difficulty and genetic complexity of the Caridina world is encoded in how many ways the contest has to slice it. Pairs with the rule that judges compare the **best three of a group**, not one animal — which is the cleanest explanation of what selective breeding actually means that this hobby has.

4. Watching creators become people. Twenty-two featured guests, scheduled meet & greets, a formal creator application

process. You watched Father Fish give a talk about deep substrates in a convention centre. There's a real observation in there about parasocial hobby media and what changes when you're in the room.

5. Seeing equipment run instead of reading about it. AQUATOP had three new all-in-ones set up and running at Booth 135. That's a verifiable hook for a broader point that matters to your audience: the gap between a spec sheet and a working tank. Balance it with the honest limitation — a show floor can't tell you about month eighteen.

Tier 2 — strong

6. Speed scaping, and what a clock does to a creative decision. Verified that it happened (four rounds across two days). Format unverified — which is actually fine, because the interesting content is the *idea*: a timer forces commitment to hardscape structure and forbids relitigation. Ties directly into planted-tank territory your audience already cares about.

7. Freshwater and reef culture under one roof — including the friction. Don't sanitise it. The crossover is the founding premise (2018, 40/40 split), and at least one reef-club attendee found the mix crowded and the reef offering thinner than a reef-only show. Two legitimate readings of the same room.

8. The "Facebook Marketplace booth." Your own joke, your own observation, unverifiable — and a genuinely good five minutes about the secondhand equipment economy in this hobby, and about how much of fishkeeping runs on other people's outgrown gear. The AAC silent auction of finished contest scapes and equipment is a verified adjacent fact you can hang it on.

9. What a festival-format show teaches versus what it doesn't. Verified structural observation: NJ 2026 had no standalone water-chemistry lecture. It had plecos, livebearers, koi judging, coral nutrition, breeding ethics, trade policy. That's a real statement about what a mass-audience event prioritises — and a fair, non-snarky place to note what clubs still do better.

10. Father Fish on a national stage — and the name on the schedule was wrong. His method (soil under three inches of sand, no CO₂, no chemical ferts, 70+ years of practice, founding board member of the National Aquarium in Baltimore) sits squarely in your domain, and the fact that Aquashella's own schedule misprinted his surname is a small, human, honest detail about how these shows actually get assembled.

Tier 3 — good supporting segments

11. Why the reef section is blue, explained for freshwater people. Clean, well-sourced, genuinely interesting, and a natural bridge segment for a freshwater show.

12. The unexpected reptile crossover. Reptiles are official, not incidental — vivarium contest with standardised 75-gallon enclosures, Lori Barczyk speaking, Dan The Turtle Man on the guest list. The red tegu is your own sighting and should be framed that way.

13. A New Jersey pond builder gets a main-stage slot at a national show. Fitz's Fish Ponds: founded from one backyard pond in 2005, now flying to Japan three times a year to hand-select koi, running its own Koi Fest. The local-business-scales story.

14. Convention livestock shopping versus online. VIP tickets have been sold on "first pick" since 2018. Balanced against transport stress, temporary display conditions, and the fact that admission is a real cost.

15. Carrying a bag of shrimp through a convention centre. The logistics of buying live animals at an event — coolers, insulated bags, a long day in a hall, the drive home — is under-discussed and practically useful to your audience.

SECTION 14 — GOOD PODCAST FACTS

Short, conversational, sourced. Each is safe to say aloud as written.

On origins

- Aquashella started in Chicago in August 2018, and the first one was only about eighty companies — it was pitched as a crossover show, roughly forty saltwater vendors and forty freshwater. (<https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/>)
- George Mavrakis — CoralFish12g on YouTube — has said the idea came to him at the end of 2017 while he was studying abroad in London, after another big Chicago aquarium event shut down. (<https://www.gridnews.net/profiles/youtuber-turns-an-aquarium-hobby-into-a-globetrotting-journey>)

- At the very first one, a day pass was fifteen dollars and it came with a pair of UV glasses.
(<https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/>)

On scale

- In 2026 Aquashella ran four cities: Orlando in March, Dallas in May, New Jersey in September, and Chicago two weeks after New Jersey. (<https://aquashella.com/>)
- The first New Jersey show, in 2025, drew over seven thousand people and more than a hundred vendors — the biggest Aquashella turnout up to that point. (<https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>)
- The New Jersey Convention and Exposition Center in Edison has somewhere around a hundred and fifty thousand square feet of exhibit space, depending on which source you read. (<https://expofp.com/njcec>)

On how it runs

- Entry is staged by the hour. Your ticket says eleven, you get scanned in between eleven and twelve, and then you can come and go for the rest of that day. (<https://aquashella.com/>)
- Doors are ten to six on Saturday and ten to five on Sunday, and both days end with a charity raffle. (<https://aquashella.com/>)

On aquascaping

- The main aquascaping contest gives selected scapers twelve hours spread over two days, and they build it out on the floor during show hours so you can stand there and watch. (<https://aquashella.com/aac/>)
- Here's the part that surprised me: every finished contest scape, and the equipment, becomes Aquashella's property and gets sold off by silent auction. (<https://aquashella.com/aac/>)
- There's a judged result and a separate People's Choice Award — the judges announce Sunday morning, the crowd's pick comes at three. (<https://aquashella.com/aac/>)
- Speed scaping is the fast version — it ran in rounds on the feature stage across both days, with a championship round on Sunday. (<https://aquashella.com/>)
- Daichi Araki, one of ADA's SUIKEI creators, taught a three-part aquascaping masterclass on a nine-hundred-millimetre ADA system. (<https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590>)

On shrimp

- The American Shrimp Contest has seven categories, and six of them are Caridina. Neocaridina — every cherry, every blue dream, every rili — all share one single category. (<https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>)
- You don't enter one shrimp, you enter a group of three to five, and the judges compare the best three. So it's rewarding a consistent line, not one lucky animal. (<https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>)
- Minimum size is three quarters of an inch, no wild-type shrimp allowed, and you have to have bred them yourself. (<https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>)
- Every contest tank runs the same way: RO water with a shrimp-specific remineraliser, sponge or motor filter, and the parameters held per category. They standardise the tanks so they're judging the shrimp, not the setup. (<https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules>)
- Neocaridina davidi hits maturity in about thirty days and lives roughly one to two years — which is part of why colour lines move so fast. (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neocaridina_davidi)
- Wild-type cherry shrimp are a mottled brown. Everything colourful in the hobby — red, orange, yellow, green, blue, violet, white — came out of selective breeding. (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neocaridina_davidi)

On reef

- Reef sections are blue because blue is what penetrates deepest in seawater — reds and oranges drop out near the surface. (<https://www.reef2reef.com/ams/the-optimal-light-spectrum-in-a-reef-aquarium.809/>)
- The symbiotic algae inside coral tissue absorb most strongly around four-twenty to four-seventy nanometres, which is right in

the blue. Those algae can supply up to about ninety percent of the coral's energy. (<https://allcorals.com/guides/reef-lighting>)

- The glow is fluorescence. Corals have proteins that soak up blue and ultraviolet and re-emit it at longer wavelengths — greens, oranges, pinks. (<https://reefcoaquariums.com/blogs/news/what-makes-corals-glow>)
- Worth knowing: cameras exaggerate that fluorescence compared to what your eye actually sees. (<https://ocdreefs.com/blue-vs-white-light-saltwater-aquarium/>)
- Blue-only isn't automatically best, either. Most corals do better long term under a broader spectrum, and white light is what makes the fish look like fish. (<https://allcorals.com/guides/reef-lighting>)

On people

- Father Fish — Lou Foxwell — has been keeping fish for over seventy years and was a founding board member of the National Aquarium in Baltimore. (<https://father-fish-aquarium.myshopify.com/pages/about-us>)
- His method is soil under about three inches of sand, planted so the soil never touches the water column. No CO₂, no chemical fertilisers. (<https://aquariumscience.org/15-17-father-fish-aquariums/>)
- Grant Eder of The Garden of Eder keeps over a hundred and forty varieties of dwarf freshwater shrimp across more than four hundred aquariums. (<https://www.facebook.com/tgoeshrimp/>)
- Vanessa Glass runs Glass Aquatics, which has been going since 2001, and her coral food line got nominated for Best New Product when it debuted at Aquashella Dallas in 2024. (<https://www.coralmagazine.com/2025/04/11/home-brew-live-feeds-an-introduction/>)
- Fitz's Fish Ponds started from one backyard pond built in 2005, and now their team flies to Japan three times a year to hand-pick koi. (<https://fitzfishponds.com/our-locations/>)

On why conventions exist

- The VIP tier has been sold on "first pick" of the livestock since the very first show in 2018. That tells you what people are actually coming for. (<https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/>)
- The founder's line is that all roads lead to koi — he'll film someone's reef tank and they'll take him out back to show him their pond. (<https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/>)

SECTION 15 — THINGS THAT SHOULD NOT BE STATED AS FACT

Read this section before writing a single line of script.

15.1 Could not be verified at all — no source found

Claim	Status
A mechanical/animatronic shark as an official NJ 2026 attraction	UNKNOWN. No source. No price documented anywhere. Never state a price.
Any vendor selling 10- and 20-gallon cube AIO tanks under \$200 at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. The only booth-confirmed AIOs were AQUATOP's 5, 8, and 9 gallon. Vendor unidentified.
A used-equipment booth at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. No vendor found.
A red tegu at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. No source. Also: "red tegu" is a distinct species from the more common Argentine black-and-white tegu — be precise or describe rather than name.
Pet Supplies Plus operating a booth / giving out swag at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. Partner status verified; booth and swag not.
Seachem exhibiting at NJ 2026, and any	

booth game or giveaway	UNKNOWN for NJ 2026. Strong pattern at other stops; not confirmed here.
SICCE exhibiting at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. No source.
LRB Aquatics at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. Not on the NJ guest list or NJ schedule. Confirmed at Orlando 2026 instead.
Blue Diamond Neocaridina available at The Garden of Eder's NJ 2026 booth	UNKNOWN. Grant Eder's presence is verified; that specific stock is not.
QR-code voting or written ballots at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. Only "People's Choice Award" and "consumer decided" are verified — the mechanism is not documented.
Speed scaping time limits, tank sizes, materials, judges, or competitors	UNKNOWN. Only that it ran, in rounds, on the feature stage.
Angelfish being unusually prevalent on the NJ 2026 floor	UNKNOWN. No photo/video corpus available.
Any NJ 2026 contest winners	UNKNOWN. No results published as of research date.
Attendance figure for NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. 7,000+ is the 2025 figure. Do not transplant it to 2026.
NJ 2026 parking cost or arrangement	UNKNOWN. Venue sources conflict; no Aquashella source addresses it.
What Dustin's Fish Tanks was selling at NJ 2026	UNKNOWN. Presence verified; inventory not.
Whether AAC voting at NJ 2026 used a particular method	UNKNOWN.
Whether any NJ 2026 session ran as scheduled	UNKNOWN in principle. Aquashella's own schedule carries a change disclaimer, and no post-event source yet exists.

15.2 Details that conflict between sources — do not pick a side on air

Conflict	Version A	Version B	Version C
Father Fish's surname	Aquashella schedule: Maxwell	Aquashella guests page: Foxwell	All independent sources: Foxwell ← use this
Aquascaping contest grand prize	NJ contests page: \$5,000	AAC page: \$1,000 Grand Champion, \$500 second, \$250 third	All-contests page: \$1,000
Aquascaping contest presenter	NJ page: Fluval	All-contests page: Aqua Forest Aquarium × ADA	—
Shrimp contest sponsor	NJ contests page: Dymax	reefs.com (Aug 2026, NJ-specific): Hikari	—
Araki masterclass start time	Aquashella: 11:00am Sat	ADA press release: 10:30am Sat	—
NJCEC exhibit space	ExpoFP: 155,277 sq ft	Cvent: 155,500 sq ft hall / 110,000 exhibit	Venue marketing: ~150,000 sq ft
NJCEC parking	ExpoFP: free, ample	Directories: 1,200 spaces	Aggregator: \$5–\$30 depending on event
Shrimp contest overall prize	Rules page: \$250 (but stated in a Daytona 2024 context)	NJ page: "cash prizes," unspecified	—

Vendor/attendance marketing numbers	Dezerland (Orlando promo): 288+ vendors, 20,000+ attendees, 100+ educators	POND Trade (NJ 2025 reporting): 100+ vendors, 7,000+ attendees	The Dezerland figures read as tour-wide or aspirational marketing, not per-show. Do not attribute them to New Jersey.
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15.3 Where the official source is unclear or unreliable

- **Aquashella's own site is inconsistently maintained.** The NJ exhibitors page embeds a **2025** floorplan URL in its source while the nav links to the 2026 one. Several "Details & Entry" buttons on the NJ contests page link to an **unrelated koi-show domain**. The homepage's headline counters for vendors, attendees, and educators render as blank "+" with no number. Contest pages carry three different prize figures. Treat any single Aquashella page as directionally right and specifically unreliable.
- **The American Shrimp Contest rules page carries stale Daytona 2024 dates, addresses, and prize figures** alongside what appear to be standing structural rules. Separate the two.
- **No NJ 2026 exhibitor list is publicly retrievable.** Any claim of the form "X had a booth at NJ 2026" must come from X's own announcement, from the Aquashella guest list, from the schedule, or from you.

15.4 Things that would be risky to state definitively

1. Any attendance number for NJ **2026**.
2. Any contest winner.
3. Any price for anything you didn't personally pay.
4. That any scheduled session happened as listed.
5. That a brand "was there" based only on partner-wall logo presence.
6. That general shrimp-judging criteria are Aquashella's criteria.
7. That the reef section's blue lighting was a deliberate zoning decision by the organisers rather than an emergent property of reef vendors all running reef lights.
8. Father Fish's surname as "Maxwell."

SECTION 16 — SOURCE LIBRARY

OFFICIAL AQUASHELLA SOURCES

Page/Title	Publisher	URL	Date	Supports
Aquashella (homepage)	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	2026 city list and dates; NJ dates/venue/hotel; full NJ 2026 schedule ; ticket tiers and prices; show hours; staged entry mechanics; FAQ; partner logo wall; five-pillar event structure; official self-description
New Jersey Guests	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Full 22-name NJ 2026 featured guest list ; NJ schedule repeat; creator application process; Fluval as mainstage/feature stage sponsor
New Jersey			Accessed	NJ 2026 contest lineup; \$5,000 AAC figure; Dymax as shrimp sponsor; Garden of Eder and Lucky Aquatics as

Contests	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/	Sep 14 2026	shrimp sponsors; guppy contest "consumer decided"; stingray, clownfish, kids, scape off, frag off
New Jersey Exhibitors	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/nj-exhibitors/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Confirms exhibitor list is floorplan-only; reveals stale 2025 embed
New Jersey Tickets	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/nj-tix/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	NJ tickets closed; NJ date/venue confirmation
AAC — Aquascaping Contest	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/aac/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	12 hours / 2 days; Fri–Sun build and judging schedule; \$1,000/\$500/\$250 prizes; People's Choice at 3pm Sunday; silent auction of scapes and equipment; selection and application rules
All Contests	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/contests/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Aqua Forest × ADA attribution and \$1,000 figure; koi contest/showcase; Dustin's kids booth check-in; vivarium contest; feature-stage siting of Scape Off and Frag Off
Aquashella Vivarium Contest	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/aquashella-vivarium-contest/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	5 designers, 8 hours Saturday; Vision Racks & Cages Model 322, 75 gal, 36×21×23; Sunday judging, 12pm winner
Aquashella for Kids	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/for-kids/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Fluval Kids Aquascaping Contest at 1pm both days; Mermaid Cove; Kids Zone
Vendor Rules and FAQs	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/vendor-rules-and-faqs/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	\$60 two-day vendor access badge; Friday check-in; Sunday 5pm–midnight teardown
Aquashella Shrimp Contest Entry	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/aquashella-shrimp-contest-entry/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Group size, judging procedure, tank spec, RO + remineraliser
Aquashella Guppy Contest Entry	Aquashella	https://www.aquashella.com/aquashella-guppy-contest-entry/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Each entry in its own 5-gallon tank; judged on pattern/size/unique features; cash prize plus People's Choice
Aquashella Koi Contest Entry	Aquashella	https://www.aquashella.com/aquashella-koi-contest-entry/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Koi contest framing (general, not NJ 2026)
Dallas Guests	Aquashella	https://aquashella.com/dallas-guests/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Home Brew coral-feed talk description; Shelby Eder listed separately
NJ 2026 floorplan	Aquashella / ExpoFP	https://aquashellanewjersey2026.expofp.com/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	Returned no readable content — documented gap
Aquashella Instagram	Aquashella	https://www.instagram.com/aquashella/?hl=en	Accessed Sep 14 2026	2026 tour date bio; 172K followers

Aquashella Facebook	Aquashella	https://www.facebook.com/aquashellafest/	Accessed Sep 14 2026	~107,000 page likes; self-description as largest aquarium event in North America
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OFFICIAL NEW JERSEY 2026 EVENT / PARTNER SOURCES

Page/Title	Publisher	URL	Date	Supports
Meet AQUATOP at Aquashella New Jersey 2026	AQUATOP	https://www.aquatop.com/blog/2026/08/aquatop-aquashella-nj-2026/	Aug 2026	Booth 135 ; AquaFin 5/8 and Ascension 9 running live; full product list; travel/transit advice; "part expo, part festival"; "one of the biggest aquarium and reptile events in the country"
Announcement of ADA Booth at AQUASHELLA 2026 in New Jersey	Aqua Design Amano	https://www.adana.co.jp/en/release/detail?id=1590	Jul 2026	Booth 223 ; ADA full-system Nature Aquarium; DOOA mini-Paludarium and automated system; Araki masterclass (10:30am per ADA); SHIZUKU workshop 1:30–3:00pm Sunday
Shrimp Contest registration open — Aquashella New Jersey	Reefs.com	https://reefs.com/shrimp-contest/	Aug 14 2026	NJ 2026 shrimp contest registration; Sept 12–13 at 97 Sunfield Ave; sponsored by Hikari

VENUE SOURCES

Page/Title	Publisher	URL	Supports
NJCEC venue overview and floor plan	ExpoFP	https://expofp.com/njcec	155,277 sq ft exhibit space; 14,500 sq ft meeting space; room for 7,500+; free on-site parking; airport shuttle and rail access
New Jersey Convention and Exposition Center	Cvent	https://www.cvent.com/venues/edison/convention-center/new-jersey-convention-and-exposition-center/venue-2ad93327-042a-4647-aba3-8f941cefcf1b	155,500 sq ft hall; 110,000 sq ft exhibit; 5 meeting rooms; ballroom 6,162 sq ft
NJ Expo	New Jersey Convention & Exposition Center	https://www.njexpoctr.com/	Venue's own "more than 150,000 sq ft" framing
NJ Convention & Exposition Ctr	Northstar Meetings Group	https://www.northstarmetingsgroup.com/Meeting-Event-Venues/Edison-NJ/Convention-Center/New-Jersey-Convention-Exposition-Ctr-p52611911	1,200 parking spaces; 24 ft ceiling; theatre 6,240; 600 booths
NJCEC listing	Yelp	https://www.yelp.com/biz/new-jersey-convention-and-exposition-center-edison	Established 1990; ~150,000 sq ft
NJ Convention & Expo Center venue page	Sulekha Events	https://events.sulekha.com/new-jersey-convention-and-exposition-center-tickets-in-edison-nj_venue_1044	Parking lots A/B/F/G/H/I, \$5–\$30 depending on event, valet available

NJCEC attraction page	Mindtrip	https://mindtrip.ai/attraction/edison-new-jersey/new-jersey-convention-exposition-center/at-KNsuv5IW	15 min from Newark airport, 40 from Midtown, 60 from NE Philadelphia
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SPEAKER SOURCES

Subject	Page/Title	URL	Supports
Vanessa Glass	Home Brew Live Feeds: An Introduction	https://www.coralmagazine.com/2025/04/11/home-brew-live-feeds-an-introduction/	Identified as reef industry professional with Glass Aquatics/HBLF; Coral Nutrition Food Pyramid; Margarita/Texas Tea/Cosmopolitan; Hurst TX; Best New Product nomination at Aquashella Dallas 2024
Vanessa Glass	About us	https://www.glassaquatics.com/about-us/	Glass Aquatics founded April 2001; Vanessa named as company president
Vanessa Glass	HBLF combines multiple species of phyto with Hydrospace PNSB	https://reefbuilders.com/2025/03/22/home-brew-live-feeds-combines-multiple-species-of-phyto-with-hydrospace-pnsb/	Texas-based small-batch phytoplankton; refill/draft dealer model; \$2 cap return
Vanessa Glass	HBLF product line	https://premiumaquatics.com/collections/brand-home-brew-live-feeds ; https://www.saltwateraquarium.com/home-brew-live-feeds/	Product range and composition
Lou Foxwell (Father Fish)	About Us	https://fatherfishaquarium.com/about-us/	Founded by Lou Foxwell; Father Fish Method; deep substrates, native microbes, live plants; Salisbury MD store; no chemicals, no CO ₂
Lou Foxwell	About us (Shopify mirror)	https://father-fish-aquarium.myshopify.com/pages/about-us	70+ years fishkeeping; career in ministry; store as retirement project; founding board member, National Aquarium in Baltimore
Lou Foxwell	A-List Talks with Father Fish	https://www.mysuncoast.com/2026/06/06/a-list-talks-with-father-fish-master-natural-aquarium/	June 2026 TV segment; name given as Lou Foxwell
Lou Foxwell	15.17 Father Fish Aquariums	https://aquariumscience.org/15-17-father-fish-aquariums/	Method breakdown: compost under ~3" sand, heavy easy-plant load, ~100 tanks in the former store
Lori Barczyk	BHB Reptiles	https://www.bhbreptiles.com/	Co-founded BHB with Brian Barczyk 1989; Lori now leads the Brian Barczyk YouTube channel; LegaSea and The Reptarium as community spaces
Lori Barczyk	LegaSea Aquarium & The Reptarium	https://legaseaaquarium.com/	30,000 sq ft Utica MI facility; reptiles, fresh and saltwater aquariums, stingrays, mammals
			Born Sep 6 1969, died Jan 14

Brian Barczyk	Wikipedia	https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brian_Barczyk	2024; 5.72M YouTube subscribers; founder of Reptarium and Legasea
LegaSea opening	The Wild Rx	https://www.thewildrx.com/2025/07/legasea-aquarium-the-reptarium-you-should-check-them-out/	LegaSea opened April 21 2025; Brian's unrealised dream; Lori operating it
Fitz's Fish Ponds	Company site / locations / Koi Fest	https://fitzfishponds.com/ ; https://fitzfishponds.com/our-locations/ ; https://fitzfishponds.com/blog/koi-fest-2026-returns-bigger-than-ever/	Founded 2008 from a 2005 backyard pond; four+ NJ retail locations; Milford farm with six greenhouses; three Japan buying trips per year; Koi Fest 2026 Aug 21–22 with Tri-State ZNA koi show
Grant Eder	Raleigh Aquarium Society bio	https://www.raleighaquariumsociety.org/bio-grant-eder	Ten years breeding; placed three times in the first US International Shrimp Competition 2016, another 2017; 130+ varieties; 300+ tanks and 40+ ponds
Grant Eder	Aquariumania (Pet Life Radio)	https://www.petliferadio.com/aquariumaniaep61.html	Early-career detail; Grand Champion at Aquarium Beautiful, Florida State Fair 2017; born Hawaii 1991
Grant Eder	GPASI speaker listing	https://gpasi.org/june-24-2022-grant-eder/	2022 counts: 300+ tanks, 40+ ponds, 130+ varieties
The Garden of Eder	Facebook / YouTube	https://www.facebook.com/tgoeshrimp/ ; https://www.youtube.com/channel/UC5m7aFCiaT13JPiAglqYSw	140+ varieties; 400–420+ aquariums; Weeki Wachee FL

VENDOR / BRAND SOURCES

Brand	URL	Supports
Seachem	https://www.seachem.com/	Current product news (Axolotl Conditioner/Buffer); Mark of the Rhino conservation campaign
Seachem / SICCE Tidal	https://www.seachem.com/tidal-filters.php ; https://keepfishkeeping.com/products/tidal-power-filters-from-seachem-sicce	Tidal filter feature set; Seachem/SICCE co-branding
LRB Aquatics	https://lrbaquatics.com/ ; https://www.tiktok.com/@lrbaquatics	Home-bred livestock; Tuesday shipping; 8+ years; "CEO of NO FILTERS"
LRB Aquatics	https://www.facebook.com/LRBAquatics/videos/i-need-this-in-my-life-one-of-the-displays-from-aquashellashrimp-aquarium-fishro/2417597255135216/	Confirms prior Aquashella attendance (event/year unspecified)
Fluval	https://fluvalaquatics.com/us/videos/aquashella-dallas-2023-live-aquascaping-contest	Fluval's own recap of its live aquascaping contest at Aquashella Dallas 2023

COMPETITION SOURCES

Page/Title	Publisher	URL	Supports

The American Shrimp Contest Rules	American Shrimp Contest	https://americanshrimpcontest.com/pages/rules	Full rulebook: 7 categories, \$25/group, 2 groups per category max, 3–5 shrimp per group, ¾" minimum, no wild type, parasite DQ, 100-tank cap, 3 judges per category, points system, Lead Judge tiebreak, tank spec with RO + remineraliser, shipping protocol, pickup rules, liability exclusion, Grant & Shelby as contacts. Carries stale Daytona 2024 dates
American Shrimp Contest — Daytona 2024 Entry	American Shrimp Contest	https://americanshrimpcontest.com/products/daytona-2024-entry	Confirms the group/size rules as the standing framework
American Shrimp Contest at Aquashella Chicago 2021	SimpleTix	https://www.simpletix.com/e/american-shrimp-contest-at-aquashella-chic-tickets-75208	2021 rules for comparison: 50-tank cap, ½" minimum — documents the rule evolution
Aquashella Shrimp Contest announcement	KC Fish Club	https://kcfishclub.org/community/announcements/aquashella-shrimp-contest/	2024 note that entrants need not attend in person
AGA Aquascaping Contest guidelines	Aquatic Gardeners Association	https://showcase.aquatic-gardeners.org/guidelines.html	General aquascape judging criteria — balance between components, effective use of space, open vs enclosed areas. Not Aquashella's rules
Scaped Contest	Nature Aquariums USA	https://natureaquariums.com/pages/scaped-contest	Different event. Example speed-scape format (4 contestants, 30 min, mystery box, audience objects) for genre explanation only

INDUSTRY PRESS / HISTORY SOURCES

Page/Title	Publisher	URL	Date	Supports
Aquashella is Bringing an Aquarium Festival to Chicago!	Reef Builders (Jake Adams)	https://reefbuilders.com/2018/06/29/aquashella-is-bringing-a-reef-aquarium-festival-to-chicago/	Jun 29 2018	Founding record: Mavrakis/CoralFish12g; Aug 18–19 2018 Chicago; 80 companies; even fresh/salt mix; art installations by ReefWeeds and Justin Credabel; \$15 day pass with UV glasses; \$75 VIP with first pick of livestock
Aquashella 2025 in Edison NJ Sees	POND Trade	https://www.pondtrademag.com/aquashella-2025-in-edison-nj-sees-record-attendance-highlights-	Oct 22	NJ 2025: 7,000+ attendees (record), 100+ vendors; koi/pond expansion; Mavrakis's "all things lead to koi"

Record Attendance	Magazine	expansion-into-koi-pondkeeping/	2025	reasoning; full 2025 contest list including guppy, clownfish, shrimp, stingray, koi, kids; named 2025 vendors
YouTuber turns hobby into a globetrotting journey	Grid News	https://www.gridnews.net/profiles/youtuber-turns-an-aquarium-hobby-into-a-globetrotting-journey	—	Shawn Hale as co-founder ; idea formed end of 2017 in London after a Chicago event closed; 2021 three-city tour with ~30,000 expected
Introducing Aquashella!	Reef2Reef	https://www.reef2reef.com/ams/introducing-aquashella-an-aquarium-festival-like-none-youve-ever-seen.441/	2018	80+ vendors, 40 saltwater / 40 freshwater split
Aquashella Aquarium Festival Offers One-of-a-Kind Experience	Reef2Reef (sponsored)	https://www.reef2reef.com/ams/aquashella-aquarium-festival-offers-one-of-a-kind-experience-with-a-cause.637/	Feb/Mar 2019	Dallas 2019 at Grand Place, Fair Park, Mar 30–31, 11am–6pm; "only event in the US to compile all aspects of the aquarium industry in one convention"
Aquashella Comes to Dezerland Park	Dezerland Park	https://dezerlandpark.com/2026/03/05/aquashella-comes-to-dezerland-park/	Mar 5 2026	Orlando 2026 promo claiming 288+ vendors, 20,000+ attendees, 100+ educators — treat as tour-wide marketing, not per-show
Aquashella: An Underwater Wonderland	Natural Environment Aquatix	https://naturalenvironmentaquatix.com/blogs/the-fish-tank-blog/aquashella-an-underwater-wonderland	Oct 2023	Vendor-eye view; first event Chicago 2018; displays ranging from shrimp up to stingrays and sharks
Aquashella New Jersey (2025 event listing)	Reefs.com	https://reefs.com/event/aquashella-new-jersey/	2025	NJ 2025 dates Sept 6–7 2025; \$30; NJCEC address
Aquashella 2025 (vendor guide)	Age of Aquariums	https://shop.ageofaquariums.biz/blogs/news/aquashella-2025	Oct 2025	Practical attendee advice; charity raffle supporting "Pets in the Classroom"; kids ticket structure

CREATOR SOURCES

Creator	URL	Supports
Dustin's Fish Tanks (Aquashella pattern)	https://www.tiktok.com/discover/woshella-kolam-renang-bareng-dustin	Kids Live Aquascaping Contest hosted at the Dustin's Fish Tanks booth at Dallas stops; main-stage speaking; "Dustin Talks Planted Tanks 101"
Dustin's Fish Tanks (Aquashella profile)	http://aquashella.com/team_mf/dustins-fish-tanks/	Archived Aquashella guest profile page
KaveMan	https://www.facebook.com/KaveManAquatics/posts/the-2025-	

Aquatics / Seachem booth	seachem_laboratories-crew-aquashella-dallas/1265337132264756/ ; https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=w-XYvORI-zs	Creator promotion of the Seachem booth at Aquashella Dallas 2025
Seachem booth Daytona 2024	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KAimeCCdtLM	Seachem booth as a gathering point at Aquashella Daytona 2024
AAC judging panel announcement	https://www.instagram.com/p/DNGn6NkT_Z6/	Referenced only — not retrievable in text ; judges unconfirmed

COMMUNITY / ATTENDEE SOURCES

Thread/Post	Publisher	URL	Date	Supports
Aquashella 2026 — Edison, NJ	ScapeCrunch	https://scapecrunch.com/threads/aquashella-2026-edison-nj.3322/	Jul 14 2026	Pre-event anticipation; Araki masterclass and SHIZUKU workshop as draws; Juris Jutjajevs said to be attending; advice: day one and early for livestock, later for workshops
Aquashella aquarium expo?	NJ Reef Club	https://www.njreefers.org/threads/aquashella-aquarium-expo.115125/	Sep 2025	2025 NJ critical feedback: ticketing site failure, long lines, scanner problems, crowding from the fresh/salt/reptile mix, reef quality below Reefapalooza, price objections. Also confirms 2025 was the first NJ edition
Reef-a-Palooza / Aquashella September	Reefs.com forum	https://reefs.com/forum/general-discussion/310731-reef-palooza-2026-around-corner-aquashella-september-1.html	Apr 2026	Regional show culture: arrive early for goodie bags; Sunday has better deals but fewer options
Every saltwater vendor at Aquashella New Jersey (2025)	Manhattan Reefs / ReefnBid	https://www.manhattanreefs.com/forum/general-discussion/309114-video-every-saltwater-vendor-aquashella-new-jersey-reefnbid-1.html	Sep 9 2025	Existence of a 2025 NJ saltwater vendor walkthrough video — names not extractable
What happened to Aquashella Orlando?	Reef2Reef	https://www.reef2reef.com/threads/what-happened-to-aquashella-orlando.961789/	Jan 2023	The 2023 contraction to Dallas and Daytona only

SCIENCE SOURCES (blue light / coral / shrimp biology)

Page/Title	Publisher	URL	Supports
Effects of LED Light Illumination on Growth, Digestive Enzymes, and Photoacclimation of <i>Goniopora</i>	PMC / peer-reviewed	https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8833557/	Blue (440–470nm) and purple (400–430nm) increased protease and body protein, growth and

<i>columna</i>			survival; 400–470nm recommended as primary illumination
Acclimatization of symbiotic corals to mesophotic light environments through wavelength transformation by fluorescent protein pigments	PMC / peer-reviewed	https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC5524488/	Photoconvertible red fluorescent proteins transform blue into orange-red that penetrates deeper into coral tissue, aiding shaded symbionts
Reef Tank Lighting Guide: PAR, Spectrum & LED Setup	AllCorals	https://allcorals.com/guides/reef-lighting	Zooxanthellae supply up to ~90% of coral energy; 420–470nm as primary absorption peak; reef tanks look blue because the spectrum is tuned to corals not eyes; fluorescent proteins as sunscreen
The Optimal Light Spectrum in a Reef Aquarium	Reef2Reef	https://www.reef2reef.com/ams/the-optimal-light-spectrum-in-a-reef-aquarium.809/	Seawater attenuation by wavelength; chlorophyll a/b/c plus carotenoid pigments; absorption high in 400–500nm and 650–700nm; red light and oxidative stress
What Makes Corals Glow?	Reefco Aquariums	https://reefcoaquariums.com/blogs/news/what-makes-corals-glow	Fluorescence mechanism; blue 400–490nm penetrates deepest; fluorescent proteins as biological sunscreen and free-radical neutralisers
Do corals prefer blue or white light?	RecifArt	https://www.recifart.com/en/blog-recifart/reef-aquarium/do-corals-prefer-white-or-blue-light	400–510nm blue range with peak near 420nm; blue-only rarely

			optimal long term
Blue vs White Light for Saltwater Aquarium	OCD Reefs	https://ocdreefs.com/blue-vs-white-light-saltwater-aquarium/	Cameras exaggerate fluorescence relative to the human eye; white light needed for natural fish colour
Neocaridina (genus)	Wikipedia	https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neocaridina	Atyidae; East Asian; ~25–30 described species; genus established by Kubo 1938
Neocaridina davidi	Wikipedia	https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neocaridina_davidi	Native range; wild type mottled brown; colour morphs; no distinct larval stage; maturity ~30 days; lifespan 1–2 years; 3–4cm adult; invasive in thermally polluted waters

SECTION 17 — FINAL RESEARCH SUMMARY

A. THE 20 MOST IMPORTANT VERIFIED FACTS ABOUT AQUASHELLA NEW JERSEY 2026

1. It ran **Saturday September 12 and Sunday September 13, 2026** at the **New Jersey Convention & Exposition Center, 97 Sunfield Ave, Edison, NJ 08837**. (*aquashella.com*)
2. Hours were **10am–6pm Saturday, 10am–5pm Sunday**, with **staged hourly entry** by ticket tier. (*aquashella.com*)
3. Ticket tiers: **VIP Weekend \$85 presale / \$99 door, Early Bird \$30/\$37, General \$25/\$30, Kids 5–12 \$12/\$18, under 4 free**. (*aquashella.com*)
4. **VIP includes a 10am entry, early-bird speakers, a YouTube meet & greet, and the official show T-shirt**, redeemed at the Aquashella Merch Booth. (*aquashella.com*)
5. This was the **second** Aquashella New Jersey; the first was September 6–7, 2025 at the same venue. (*reefs.com; njreefers.org*)
6. **Twenty-two featured guests** were listed, including Dustin's Fish Tanks, Grant Eder, Louis Foxwell (Father Fish), George Mavrakis, Brett Raymer, Polo Reef, Octo Nation, Kaveman Aquatics, The Reef Vet, and Dan The Turtle Man. (*aquashella.com/new-jersey-guests/*)
7. **Eleven distinct speaker sessions** ran across two days on the Speaker Stage. (*aquashella.com*)
8. **Vanessa Glass of Home Brew Live Feeds spoke Sunday at 12:00pm on *The Coral Food Nutrition Pyramid***. (*aquashella.com*)
9. **Lou "Father Fish" Foxwell spoke Sunday at 2:15pm on *Natural Aquarium Methods***. (*aquashella.com*)
10. **Fitz's Fish Ponds presented *What are Competitive Koi?* Saturday at 1:00pm**. (*aquashella.com*)

11. **Daichi Araki of ADA** taught a three-part Aquascaping Masterclass Saturday on an **ADA W900mm full system**. (aquashella.com; adana.co.jp)
12. **ADA exhibited at Booth 223** with US distributor **Aqua Forest Aquarium**, showing a full-system Nature Aquarium plus DOOA paludarium products. (adana.co.jp)
13. **AQUATOP exhibited at Booth 135**, running three new all-in-one systems live: **AquaFin 5, AquaFin 8, Ascension 9**. (aquatop.com)
14. The **DOOA Glass Pot SHIZUKU workshop** ran on the Feature Stage Sunday **1:30–3:00pm**. (aquashella.com; adana.co.jp)
15. **Speed Scaping** ran in **four blocks**: Rounds 1 and 2 Saturday (12pm, 2pm), Round 3 Sunday 11am, **Championships Sunday 12pm**. (aquashella.com)
16. The **Aquashella Aquascaping Contest** ran as a **12-hour, two-day live build**, with **awards Sunday morning** and a separate **People's Choice Award at 3:00pm Sunday**. (aquashella.com/aac/)
17. **All finished contest scapes and their equipment become Aquashella property and are sold by silent auction**. (aquashella.com/aac/)
18. NJ 2026 contests included the **American Shrimp Contest** (registration opened August 2026, sponsored per that announcement by **Hikari**), **Clownfish Contest**, **Guppy Contest** (explicitly consumer-decided), **USA Stingray Competition** with Predatory Fins (\$1,000), **Frag Off**, and the **Dustin's Fish Tanks Kids Aquascaping Contest**. (aquashella.com/new-jersey-contests/; reefs.com)
19. A **panel on current pressures on the aquarium trade**, with the **Pet Advocacy Network and USAqua**, ran Saturday 3:45pm — the most policy-oriented item on the program. (aquashella.com)
20. **Lori Barczyk**, CEO/Founder of **Legasea Aquarium and The Reptarium**, spoke Saturday 4:30pm on *Building a Legacy*. (aquashella.com)

B. THE 10 STRONGEST GENERAL AQUASHELLA BACKGROUND FACTS

1. **First event: Chicago, August 18–19, 2018**, with about 80 companies and a deliberate ~40 saltwater / 40 freshwater split. (*Reef Builders*)
2. **Founded by George Mavrakis (CoralFish12g)**, with **Shawn Hale** as co-founder. (*Reef Builders*; *Grid News*)
3. The concept formed at the **end of 2017**, while Mavrakis was studying abroad in London, after a large Chicago aquarium event closed down. (*Grid News*)
4. At launch it was **art-led, not speaker-led** — coral art installations instead of a lecture program. By 2026 it advertises two stages of speakers. (*Reef Builders*; aquashella.com)
5. **First-pick livestock access has been the VIP selling point since 2018**. (*Reef Builders*)
6. The tour has **expanded and contracted**: three cities in 2021, down to just **Dallas and Daytona in 2023**, back to four cities in 2026. (*Grid News*; *Reef2Reef*; aquashella.com)
7. **Aquashella New Jersey 2025 was the largest show to date: 7,000+ attendees, 100+ vendors**. (*POND Trade*)
8. Mavrakis's stated thesis is that **koi is the hobby's intersection point** — reef keepers with ponds, pond owners with office reefs. (*POND Trade*)
9. **Reptiles are an official category**, formalised through a judged **Vivarium Contest** using standardised 75-gallon Vision Racks & Cages enclosures. (aquashella.com)
10. The **American Shrimp Contest has grown from a 50-tank, ½-inch-minimum event in 2021 to a 100-tank, ¾-inch-minimum, seven-category contest** with three judges per category. (*SimpleTix 2021*; americanshrimpcontest.com)

C. THE 10 STRONGEST COMMUNITY / CULTURAL OBSERVATIONS

(Labelled — several are community-sourced, not fact.)

1. **VERIFIED:** Creator access is a designed, scheduled product — twice-daily meet & greets, a formal creator application, and a "YouTube meet & greet" written into the VIP tier.
2. **VERIFIED:** Aquascaping is built to be watched. Contest scaping is deliberately scheduled during public hours so attendees can talk to scapers mid-build.
3. **VERIFIED:** The show is explicitly family-structured — kids ticket tier, free under 4, Kids Zone, Mermaid Cove, a kids aquascaping contest at 1pm both days.
4. **VERIFIED:** Beginner and advanced audiences are served from the same stage; the official framing is "entry level to advanced."
5. **COMMUNITY:** Experienced attendees advise **day one and early for livestock and plants, later in the weekend for workshops and conversation** — a real, practical split in how people use the show.
6. **COMMUNITY:** Sunday tends to bring better deals and thinner selection, as vendors would rather sell than pack.
7. **COMMUNITY:** The fresh/salt/reptile crossover is polarising. One 2025 NJ attendee found it produced dense browsing crowds and rated the reef offering below a reef-only show, and said they wouldn't return.
8. **COMMUNITY:** The 2025 NJ entry experience drew real complaints — ticketing site failure, long lines, scanner trouble.
9. **COMMUNITY:** Admission pricing is contested. Some hobbyists opted out at \$30 presale / \$37 door.
10. **FIRSTHAND ONLY:** The sense of belonging. Nothing external measures it, nothing needs to, and it's the part of the story only you can tell.

D. THE 10 DETAILS THAT STILL NEED VERIFICATION

1. **Complete NJ 2026 exhibitor/vendor list** — not publicly retrievable in any form.
2. **NJ 2026 attendance figure** — unknown. Do not reuse 2025's 7,000.
3. **Contest winners** — none published as of Sept 14, 2026.
4. **Whether each scheduled session actually ran** — the schedule carries a change disclaimer and no post-event source exists yet.
5. **Speed scaping format** — time limits, tank size, materials, judges, competitors: all unknown.
6. **Voting mechanism** (QR code, ballot, app) for People's Choice and the consumer-decided guppy contest.
7. **Which brands actually had NJ booths** versus which are merely 2026-season partners — specifically Seachem, SICCE, Hikari, Pet Supplies Plus.
8. **The identity of the AIO tank vendor** selling 10- and 20-gallon cubes under \$200, if such a vendor existed.
9. **The used-equipment booth** — vendor unidentified.
10. **The mechanical shark** — no documentation of any kind, and no price anywhere.

Plus three unresolved conflicts to keep in mind: the aquascaping grand prize (\$5,000 vs \$1,000), the shrimp contest sponsor (Dymax vs Hikari), and Father Fish's surname (Maxwell on the schedule vs Foxwell everywhere else).

E. THE 5 STRONGEST POTENTIAL PODCAST THEMES

1. **The hobby's silos are mostly imaginary.** Founder-sourced, fully quotable, and the best organising idea in the research. All roads lead to koi. Freshwater, reef, pond, reptile under one roof isn't a merchandising accident — it's the founding argument, running since a deliberate 40/40 vendor split in 2018. Your firsthand account of walking from a planted display into a blue-lit reef section and then past a tegu is the proof.
2. **A solitary hobby, briefly made social.** Most people keep fish alone, in one room, mostly reading about it online. Then seven thousand people show up in a convention hall in Edison and it turns out there's a whole physical world attached. This is the emotional spine, and it's yours to carry.
3. **What contest structure teaches about selective breeding.** Six Caridina categories to one Neocaridina category. Three-to-

five-shrimp groups judged on the best three. Standardised tanks with RO and remineraliser so it's the shrimp being judged, not the setup. Bred-it-yourself as an entry requirement. This is a genuinely educational segment that lands squarely in Tank Guide territory and is fully sourced.

4. Seeing the thing instead of reading about the thing. Equipment running live at Booth 135. Livestock you can look at before you buy. Aquascapers building where you can ask them questions. Balanced honestly against what a show floor *can't* tell you — month-eighteen reliability, long-term plant health, whether that animal looks like that in six months — plus the real limitations of crowds, impulse pressure, and a long day for a bagged animal.

5. The clock as a creative tool. Speed scaping on the feature stage next to a twelve-hour contest build on the floor: two different answers to the same question about how much deliberation a scape actually needs. Grounded in the fact that composition is largely decided at hardscape, and honest about the limitation — a timed scape is a composition exercise, not a tank that has to still look good in a year.

End of research dossier. No podcast script, titles, or intro written, as instructed.